Do Representation Gaps Cause Far-Right Support?*

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Abstract

European mainstream parties are perceived as more liberal on immigration than the voters they seek to represent. In an information experiment during Germany's 2025 election campaign, we study whether this representation gap causes far-right support. We randomly vary the truthful information participants receive about the center-right CDU's candidates, which shifts the party's perceived position. A more liberal perceived CDU position raises vote intention for the far-right AfD among conservative voters, a majority of the electorate. Liberal voters evaluate the CDU more favorably without a detectable vote change. The same information makes conservative voters feel less represented by the CDU and liberal voters more represented, and the two responses largely offset in the aggregate. The pattern indicates spatial substitution between the mainstream right and the far right rather than legitimation of the far right. Our results suggest that where mainstream parties are believed to stand on immigration determines whom they leave unrepresented, and whom the far right can reach.

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JEL Codes: D72, C93, K37.

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1 Introduction

On immigration, the issue that organizes far-right competition across Europe, mainstream parties are more liberal than the general population, and voters perceive them as such (Guenther, Forthcoming). We refer to this perceived distance as a *representation gap*. Germany is a case in point. In all but one of the 32 waves of the GLES tracking survey between 2009 and 2023, German voters on average perceived every mainstream party, the center-right CDU/CSU (henceforth CDU) included, as more liberal on immigration than themselves (Figure 1). The far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD), founded in 2013, occupied the otherwise empty space to the CDU's right and, in the February 2025 federal election, became the second-largest party.

Far-right parties have become a permanent feature of electoral competition in Western democracies, with consequences for economic policy, institutions, and growth (Funke et al., 2023; Guriev and Papaioannou, 2023), and much of what we know about their rise concerns the demand side: trade shocks, economic insecurity, and new communication technologies have made more voters receptive to their offer (Autor et al., 2020; Colantone and Stanig, 2018a; Fetzer, 2019; Zhuravskaya et al., 2020). Yet whether a receptive voter actually moves to the far right also depends on the supply side, that is, on where the mainstream parties stand, and mainstream parties across Europe are now moving toward restrictive immigration positions on the premise that it does. We ask whether the representation gap causes far-right support: does a mainstream party that is perceived as more liberal on immigration lose voters to the far right, and if so, which voters?

Spatial voting theory gives a sharp but heterogeneous answer (Downs, 1957; Persson and Tabellini, 2002). When the center-right party is perceived to move left, voters to its right become more distant from their closest mainstream option and gain a reason to defect to the far right, a response we call *spatial substitution*. Voters to its left become better represented and gain a reason to support it. Voters near the party have little reason to change anything. The population-average effect is therefore not a structural constant. It aggregates responses of opposite sign, and a small average can coexist with large effects among the voters who decide elections. Any test of the spatial account must be conducted where the theory makes its predictions: across the distribution of voter positions. Such a test also separates spatial

substitution from a rival account. Under *legitimation*, a mainstream party that moves toward the far right validates positions previously considered extreme, so that the far right gains among conservative voters; under the spatial account it loses them to the mainstream party. The two accounts predict opposite signs for the same voters.

Estimating the *positional channel*, the effect of a party's perceived policy position alone, from actual party movements is difficult, because repositioning changes more than policy distance. It also changes issue salience, the credibility of the party's commitments, coalition expectations, media coverage, and the perceived legitimacy of previously stigmatized positions. Recent quasi-experimental studies of mainstream-party accommodation estimate the bundled effect of particular political events and reach different conclusions (Becker and Hager, 2025; Turnbull-Dugarte et al., 2026). This hurdle calls for a design in which the perceived position of one party and nothing else changes.

This paper provides such a design. We conduct a pre-registered information-provision experiment with 5,040 German citizens during the campaign preceding the February 2025 federal election. Participants first report their own immigration attitude and their beliefs about every major party's position on a common 0–10 scale. They then receive truthful information from a survey of parliamentary candidates that places the CDU at one of four positions on that scale, 4, 5, 6, or 7, while the information about every other party is held fixed. Each value is the median of a random subsample of eleven of the 141 CDU candidates, and 4 to 7 are the values such a median takes with high probability, so every participant sees a truthful summary of actual candidate responses and is told how it was computed. Assignment is randomized separately within each of the eleven values of respondents' own attitude, so that treatment comparisons within any group of voters are themselves randomized experiments. The survey then measures beliefs about party positions, felt representation by the CDU, vote intentions, party evaluations, and three pre-registered behavioral measures of party support: opening a party's newsletter subscription page, the compensation required to permit a real donation to the party, and the allocation of the party's official campaign advertisements to participants in a future study. An obfuscated follow-up one week later re-elicits vote intentions and evaluations.

The information moves beliefs about the CDU and leaves nearly every other belief unchanged.

A one-point more liberal signal shifts the perceived CDU position by half a point, and the shift does not differ significantly across liberal, moderate, and conservative voters. It also moves where respondents expect the CDU to stand in five years, so they read the information as revealing a durable party position rather than a survey curiosity. The signal does not change respondents' own immigration attitudes, their beliefs about the AfD's position, the importance they attach to immigration, or their expectations about vote shares and coalitions.

We present two sets of results. First, a more liberal perceived CDU position raises support for the far-right AfD, and the gain comes from voters with conservative immigration attitudes. For these voters, a one-point more liberal signal raises AfD vote intention by 1.7 percentage points and the AfD thermometer by 0.04 standard deviations. Scaled by belief updating, the effect of a one-point more liberal perceived CDU position is about twice as large under two-stage least squares (2SLS) and larger under local least squares (LLS). Liberal voters respond in the other direction, but not detectably with their votes: their evaluation of the CDU improves by 0.06 standard deviations per signal point, while their vote intentions and their support for the AfD are within sampling error. We detect no response among moderate voters. These are the signs the spatial model predicts: the AfD gains among voters to the CDU's right, and voters to its left warm to the CDU. The conservative-versus-liberal difference in the AfD vote response is significant under the reduced form and 2SLS, and across the eleven randomization strata the response increases on average with the voter's own attitude, the gradient the model predicts. The results are also the opposite of what legitimation predicts: a CDU signal one point closer to the AfD lowers AfD vote intention among conservative voters rather than raising it.

As the theory predicts, the pooled estimate understates the response. In the full sample, a one-point more liberal signal raises AfD vote intention by 1.1 percentage points, the composition-weighted average of a large response among conservative voters, a majority of the electorate,[1] and no detectable response elsewhere. Read in the other direction, a CDU that closes the gap lowers AfD vote intention among conservatives and loses goodwill among liberal voters without a detectable gain in their votes. Hence, the electoral return to a mainstream party's position is a

[1] In the 2021–2023 waves of the GLES tracking survey, 58 percent of the 7,966 respondents, weighted with the survey weights, place themselves at 7 or above on the same 0–10 immigration item, the range we call conservative in Section 3.1. In our sample the share is 63 percent (3,165 of 5,040), and 57 percent once East and West Germany are reweighted to their national population shares (Appendix Figure A.2).

function of the preference distribution it faces.

Second, the evidence points to representation as the mechanism. The same information moves felt representation by the CDU in opposite directions on the two sides of the policy space: liberal voters, for whom the CDU moves closer, feel better represented by it, and conservative voters, for whom it moves farther away, feel worse represented. In the pooled sample the two responses largely offset and the aggregate estimate is not statistically significant, as the spatial model allows for an electorate with voters on both sides of the CDU: the pooled estimate conceals a mechanism that operates on each side. Together with the vote and evaluation results, this is the pattern the spatial account requires.

Two further results are less precise. Under LLS, conservative voters also move on two behavioral margins in the direction of substitution: they shift campaign help away from the CDU, at every bandwidth we examine, and open the AfD newsletter page more often. Under the design-based estimators the behavioral measures are imprecise, with confidence intervals that include both zero and effects nearly the size of the thermometer response, as behavioral responses to information typically are (Haaland et al., 2023). The response is concentrated in East Germany, and the one-week follow-up is too imprecise to detect either persistence or decay, so we read the main estimates as the short-run response to perceived positioning during an active campaign.

Related literature. The paper contributes to three literatures. The first is the political economy of populism and the far right (Guriev and Papaioannou, 2023). Existing work documents demand-side drivers in trade exposure (Autor et al., 2020; Colantone and Stanig, 2018a,b), economic insecurity (Algan et al., 2017; Fetzer, 2019; Funke et al., 2016; Guiso et al., 2024), and communication technology (Campante et al., 2018; Guriev et al., 2021; Liberini et al., 2025; Zhuravskaya et al., 2020). Guiso et al. (2026) frame the rise of populism as the meeting of this demand with a supply of parties willing to serve it, where supply is a platform choice. Fernández-Villaverde and Sanz (2024) show that supply matters on its most basic margin, whether a far-right party runs at all: when an internal dispute kept Vox off the ballot in one Spanish constituency in 2023, the mainstream right captured about four fifths of its vote. We hold the far-right option fixed and add causal evidence on one supply-side determinant that is

directly adjustable by political actors: the position of the mainstream party closest to the far right. Related work in political science asks whether mainstream parties should accommodate or distance themselves from the radical right on immigration (Abou-Chadi and Krause, 2020; Hjorth and Larsen, 2022; Krause et al., 2023; Meguid, 2005). These studies estimate the net effect of a party's strategy, in which a change of position arrives together with the salience, credibility, and coalition signals that accompany it, from observed party movements or from vignettes, and they estimate it for the electorate as a whole. We isolate the positional channel and estimate it across the distribution of voter attitudes, and their mixed conclusions are what that dependence would imply: the effect of a given position depends on the voters it faces.

The second is the literature on information-provision experiments in political economy (Haaland et al., 2023). Information treatments have been used to study attitudes toward immigration (Alesina et al., 2023; Grigorieff et al., 2023; Guenther, 2025), climate policy (Dechezleprêtre et al., 2025), redistribution (Kuziemko et al., 2015), and expectations (Link et al., 2023; Roth and Wohlfart, 2020; Roth et al., 2022), and survey experiments have estimated the effects of party positions on evaluations (Chou et al., 2021; Dai and Kustov, 2024; Grewenig et al., 2020; Hjorth and Larsen, 2022). We depart from this work in three ways: the manipulated object is a measured belief, the perceived immigration position of a named party in the election it was contesting, moved by truthful information rather than by hypothetical party profiles or vignette statements; the outcomes include incentivized behaviors; and randomization is stratified on the dimension along which the theory predicts heterogeneity, so that every within-attitude comparison is itself a randomized experiment. Information experiments identify the effect of beliefs through 2SLS, which weights individuals by how much they update (Angrist and Imbens, 1995; Imbens and Angrist, 1994); Balla-Elliott (2026) shows that this weighting can misrepresent the average response when updating and responsiveness are related and proposes LLS, which we report alongside 2SLS and the reduced form throughout.

The third is the literature on political representation. Representation gaps between parties and voters are widespread on cultural issues (Guenther, Forthcoming). Castanho Silva and Wratil (2023) experimentally vary whether participants learn that some party represents their views and find no effect on populist attitudes. We manipulate the perceived position of a named

mainstream party and measure both felt representation and choices among parties. The results show that a representation gap on a single issue changes electoral support even though it leaves voters' own policy preferences unchanged. That contrast also speaks to the party-cue literature, in which voters move their own positions toward their party's (Barber and Pope, 2019; Bullock, 2011; Grewenig et al., 2020): here voters keep their positions and change party.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 describes the setting and derives the predictions. Section 3 presents the experiment, Section 4 the estimators, and Section 5 the results. Section 6 discusses magnitudes, external validity, and implications.

2 Setting and Predictions

2.1 Political Setting

Germany has a proportional parliamentary system historically anchored by the center-right Christian Democratic Union and its Bavarian sister party (CDU/CSU, henceforth CDU) and the center-left Social Democratic Party (SPD). The far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD), founded in 2013, entered the Bundestag in 2017 and became the first party to the right of the CDU to obtain sustained national representation since the consolidation of the postwar party system. The CDU is therefore the AfD's closest mainstream competitor on the policy dimension we study.

Immigration is the issue on which this competition is sharpest. Figure 1 uses the German Longitudinal Election Study (GLES, 2023) to compare voters' immigration preferences with their perceptions of party positions from 2009 to 2023. In 31 of the 32 waves, the average voter perceived every mainstream party, including the CDU, as more liberal on immigration than themselves (the exception is May 2012, when the CDU was perceived 0.12 points to the voters' right), while the AfD, in every wave since its founding, occupied the otherwise empty part of the policy space to the CDU's right. The gap widened during the 2015–16 refugee crisis, when the CDU was perceived as moving in a liberal direction and AfD support rose sharply. The series is descriptive, but it identifies the configuration that motivates the experiment: a conservative electorate, a mainstream right perceived to its left, and a far-right party positioned to exploit the

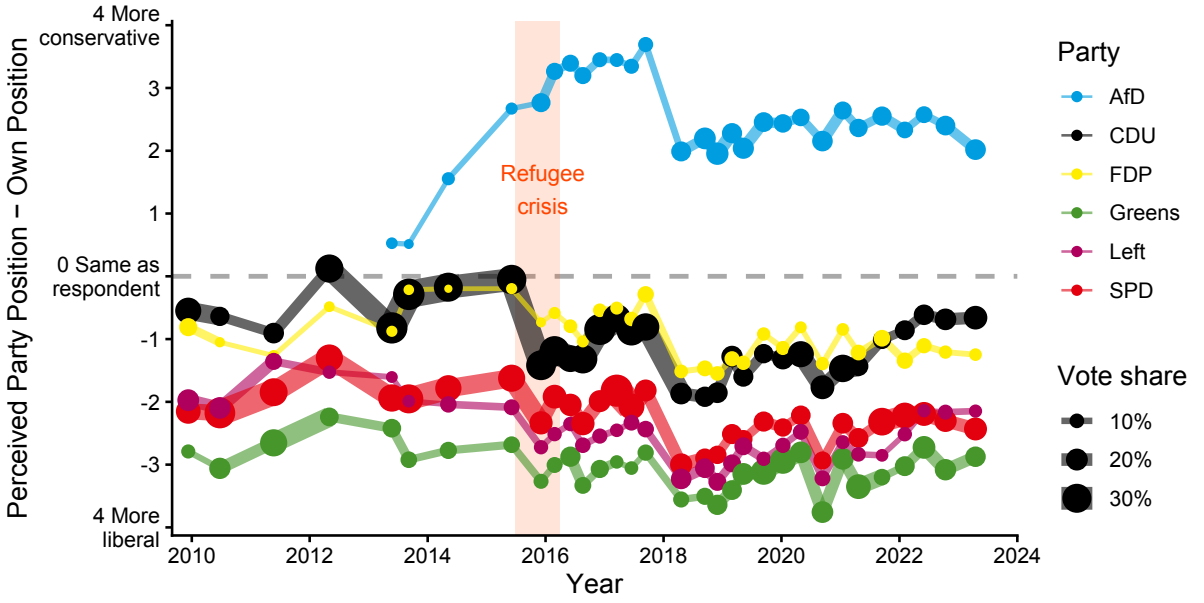


Figure 1: Perceived Immigration Stance of German Parties Relative to Voters
Note: Each point plots the weighted average of (perceived party position − respondent's own position) on a 0–10 immigration scale across all respondents in a given GLES wave. Positive values indicate that voters perceive the party as more conservative than themselves; negative values indicate more liberal. Point size is proportional to the party's vote-intention share. The shaded region marks the 2015–16 refugee crisis. Source: GLES (2023).

gap.

The 2025 campaign combined a salient immigration debate with real uncertainty about the CDU's position: under Friedrich Merz the party signaled a more restrictive direction than the Merkel governments had taken. Germany's cordon sanitaire, an informal agreement among mainstream parties not to cooperate with the AfD, made the CDU's positioning relative to the AfD politically consequential. By the campaign, the AfD polled at approximately 20 percent, second behind the CDU.

2.2 Spatial Predictions

We organize the analysis with a spatial voting model in which the effect of a party's perceived position varies across the electorate. Voter i has an ideal immigration position $x_i \in [0, 10]$ and holds a belief m_i about the CDU's position, with larger values denoting more restrictive positions. Voter i evaluates party p by quadratic policy loss, $V_i(p) = -(x_i - \pi_p)^2 + v_p$, where π_p is the party's perceived position, so $\pi_C = m_i$, and v_p collects every other consideration, including the party's positions on other issues. Immigration need not be the only issue voters care about:

any consideration the information does not move enters v_p and does not affect the predictions below.[2] Define $\ell_i = -m_i$, so that an increase in ℓ_i is a more liberal perceived CDU position. For a voter choosing between the CDU and the AfD, whose perceived position π_A the information does not change, the AfD–CDU utility difference is

$$\Delta_i(m_i) = -(x_i - \pi_A)^2 + (x_i - m_i)^2 + (v_A - v_C),$$

and a more liberal perceived CDU position changes it at the rate

$$\frac{\partial \Delta_i}{\partial \ell_i} = 2(x_i - m_i).$$

Three predictions follow; Appendix B states them for a general voting rule. First, a *single-crossing* property: the effect of a liberal shift in the perceived CDU position on the relative attractiveness of the AfD over the CDU increases in x_i, and it is negative for voters to the left of the perceived CDU position, zero for a voter located at it, and positive for voters to its right. For voters to the CDU's right, a liberal shift widens their distance to the CDU and leaves their distance to the AfD unchanged, so the AfD becomes relatively more attractive. We call this response *spatial substitution*. For voters to the CDU's left, the same shift brings the CDU closer. For voters near the CDU, it has little effect. Second, an *aggregation* property: the population effect is the composition-weighted average of these heterogeneous responses, so that a modest average is compatible with large effects in one part of the electorate, and the aggregate depends on the distribution of voter positions rather than on individual responsiveness alone. Third, a *representation* property: if felt representation declines in the distance between a voter and a party, a liberal CDU shift reduces felt representation to the CDU's right and raises it to the CDU's left, and these responses can offset in the aggregate even when representation changes systematically within groups. The representation property is the single-crossing property applied to felt representation rather than to vote choice; because it concerns one party only, it holds on both sides of the policy space without any assumption about which party the voter would

[2] Quadratic loss is not needed for the predictions. With $V_i(p) = -L(x_i - \pi_p) + v_p$ for any differentiable, strictly convex loss L with its minimum at zero, $\partial \Delta_i / \partial \ell_i = L'(x_i - m_i)$, which changes sign at $x_i = m_i$ and increases in x_i (Appendix B).

otherwise choose.

In Germany, where most respondents place themselves to the right of their perceived CDU position, the model predicts the strongest political response among voters with conservative immigration attitudes, a response of the opposite sign in felt representation among liberal voters, and a pooled estimate that understates both.

2.3 Alternative Accounts

Two prominent alternatives make different predictions within the channel our experiment manipulates. Under a *protest voting* account, far-right support expresses generalized discontent rather than policy proximity, so a marginal change in a mainstream party's perceived position should have no systematic effect, and no effect that varies with the voter's own position in the predicted direction. Under a *legitimation* account, a mainstream party perceived as closer to the far right validates positions previously considered extreme. The account has empirical support outside the positional channel: Bursztyn et al. (2020) show that the electoral success of a candidate with xenophobic positions raised voters' willingness to express them, Valentim (2021) that parliamentary representation normalizes radical-right support, and Bischof and Wagner (2019) that the entry of radical parties into parliament moves voters' positions. Applied to a mainstream party's position, it predicts that a CDU perceived as closer to the AfD raises AfD support among conservative voters, because it makes the AfD's positions acceptable. The spatial account predicts the opposite for exactly those voters: the AfD loses support among them. Because the two accounts predict opposite signs for the AfD in the same group, the sign of the response decides which of them dominates within the positional channel. It does not rule out protest or legitimation mechanisms that operate through rhetoric, elite cues, coalition behavior, or repeated exposure, which a one-shot informational manipulation holds fixed.

3 Experimental Design

The design and the analysis were pre-registered before data collection: the four information conditions, the eleven outcomes, the two party-support indexes, the reduced-form and instru-

mented analyses, the manipulation check, the mechanism questions, the sample restrictions used as robustness checks, and four heterogeneity dimensions.[3] We note each departure from the plan where it arises.

3.1 Sample and Procedure

We designed the survey in Qualtrics and recruited participants through the market-research company Cint. The main survey was fielded from December 17, 2024, to February 14, 2025; the federal election took place on February 23. As pre-registered, we targeted 5,000 German adults, 3,000 from the Eastern states and 2,000 from the Western states, because AfD support is historically stronger in the East (Cantoni et al., 2018, 2026); soft quotas on gender, age, and education targeted the distribution of the adult population on these dimensions. Because assignment is randomized within attitude strata, the oversample does not affect the internal validity of the estimates within any group; Appendix G reports the estimates by region. The analysis sample contains 5,040 participants, 3,037 from East Germany and 2,003 from West Germany, after the exclusion of 87 speeders described below. The median completion time in the analysis sample was 10.4 minutes.

Participants first report their own immigration attitude and their beliefs about each major party's immigration position. Both are elicited on the same 0–10 scale, where 0 means that immigration opportunities should be strongly facilitated and 10 that they should be strongly restricted. Participants then receive information about party positions, report posterior beliefs, complete the outcome blocks in random order, and report felt representation and their expectations about the election. Placing voters, party beliefs, and experimental signals on one scale is what allows us to test the spatial predictions directly. Appendix Figure A.1 displays the survey sequence, and Appendix I reproduces the question wording.

Assignment to the four signals was randomized separately within each of the eleven pre-treatment attitude values: the survey instrument branches on this variable, so the treatment comparison within every exact attitude value is a randomized experiment. For exposition we combine the strata into three groups defined by immigration attitudes: liberal (0–4, 823

[3]The pre-analysis plan is available at https://osf.io/5kjmt.

respondents), moderate (5–6, 1,052 respondents), and conservative (7–10, 3,165 respondents). Own attitude is not among the four heterogeneity dimensions of the pre-analysis plan, and the cutoffs were chosen after data collection.[4] Appendix D shows that the results do not depend on the grouping. Pre-treatment covariates are balanced across arms (Appendix Table A.1).

3.2 Response Quality

Participants who failed the initial captcha or attention check were screened out and contributed no data. Following Alesina et al. (2023), participants were told that low-quality responses could be flagged to the recruiting platform. A second attention check at the end of the survey was passed by 92 percent of participants (4,640 of 5,040), and a closing question asked whether the survey seemed politically biased: 77 percent (3,901 of 5,040) perceived no bias, and the remainder split roughly evenly between a left-wing and a right-wing bias. Trust in the information does not differ across treatment arms (joint test, $p = .59$). Following the survey firm's operational rule, 87 respondents who completed the survey in less than one-third of the median completion time of all completers (10.3 minutes) were replaced during data collection and excluded from the analysis sample. This exclusion was not pre-registered, so Appendix Tables F.1 and F.2 report the estimates with these respondents included, together with the pre-registered restrictions to attentive respondents and to respondents who found the information credible.

3.3 The Information Treatment

We construct party-position information from surveys of candidates in the 2021 federal election who answered the same immigration question as our participants. These were the most recent candidate surveys available when we fielded ours, and the information screen says so. Following previous work, we measure a party's position by the median response of its candidates (Costello et al., 2020; Dalton, 2017; Guenther, Forthcoming). The positions shown for the AfD, SPD, Greens, FDP, and Left are the medians of all available candidates. The CDU position is the median in a random subsample of 11 of the 141 available CDU candidates. Actual subsamples

[4]The cutoffs bracket the signal range: every signal value is at or below every conservative attitude and at or above every liberal attitude, so the side of the policy space on which the information places the CDU relative to the voter is the same for every member of these two groups, whatever the prior; moderate attitudes lie inside the range.

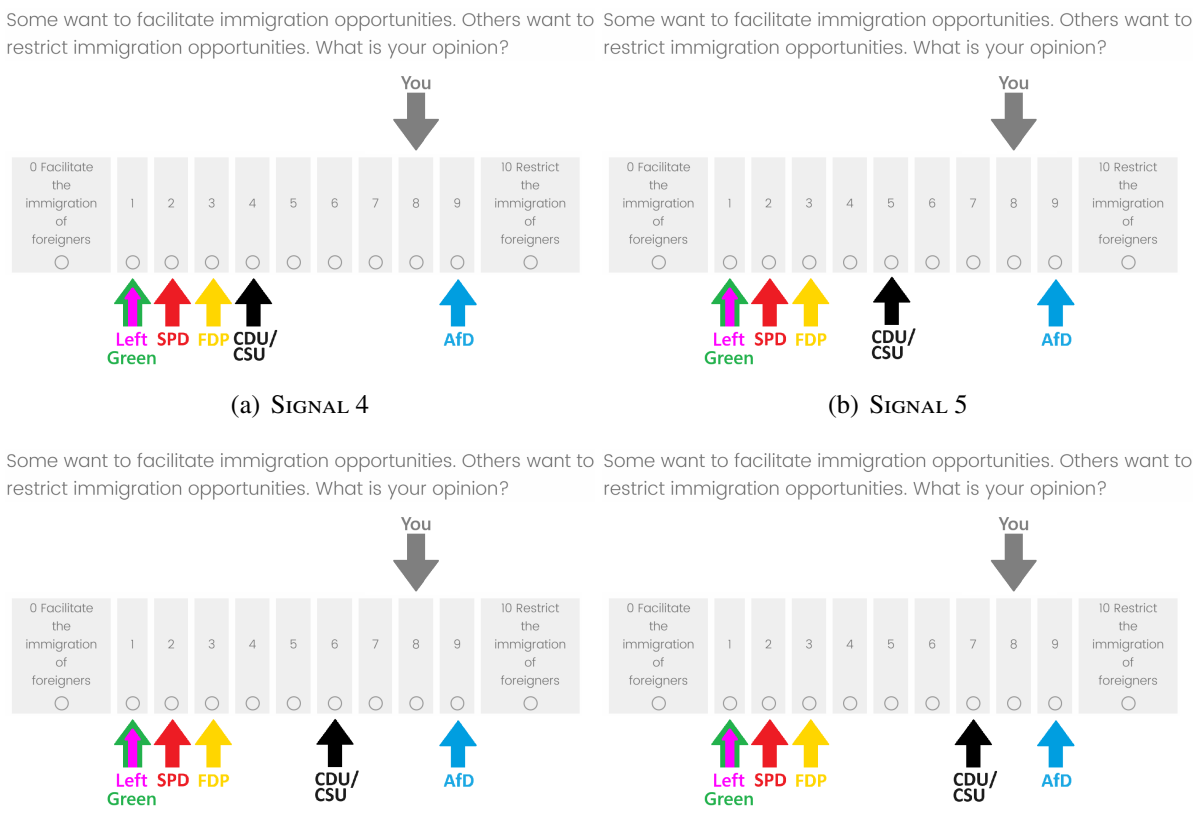
produce four values with high probability, 4, 5, 6, and 7, and we assign these values with equal probability to maximize power.[5] Every value shown is therefore a truthful summary of actual candidate responses, and the survey text explains both the source and the number of candidates used.[6] The four values sit in the middle of the distribution of pre-treatment beliefs about the CDU's position, which has a mean of 5.8 and a standard deviation of 2.9: 46 percent of respondents place the party between 4 and 7, 22 percent below 4, and 32 percent above 7, so the information can move beliefs in either direction.

The design has no uninformed arm. Every participant sees a screen of the same form, with the same positions for the other five parties, and the arms differ only in the CDU value, so the effect of the perceived CDU position is identified as a slope across arms that are alike in every other respect. A comparison with an uninformed arm would instead bundle that effect with the effect of receiving information about party positions at all, including the attention the screen draws to immigration and to the parties (Haaland et al., 2023). The same feature narrows the scope for experimenter demand: a demand effect would have to come from the one number that differs across arms, and Section 5.1 shows that this number does not change whether respondents perceive the survey as politically biased.

Figure 2 shows the four screens. The screen also displays the respondent's own position and a short verbal description of each party's position. Because the survey's raw scale assigns larger values to more restrictive positions while the paper states effects in the liberal direction, we define Liberal Signal$_i$ = −Raw Signal$_i$ and Liberal Posterior$_i$ = −Raw Posterior$_i$. The reversal preserves units: a one-unit increase in either variable is a one-unit more liberal position, and Liberal Posterior$_i$ is the empirical counterpart of $\ell_i = -m_i$, the liberal-coded perceived CDU position of the model in Section 2.2. All coefficients follow this convention.

[5]The median of all 141 CDU candidates is 5, and the median of a random subsample of 11 takes the values 4, 5, 6, and 7 with probabilities of 10, 54, 28, and 7 percent, and a value outside this range with probability 1 percent.

[6]Providing different participants with truthful information from different sources, or from different subsamples of the same source, is standard practice in information-provision experiments (Haaland et al., 2023, Section 4.2). For example, Roth and Wohlfart (2020) show respondents one of two macroeconomic forecasts drawn from a survey of professional forecasters. Appendix I reproduces the full text of the information screen.



(a) Signal 4 (b) Signal 5

(c) Signal 6 (d) Signal 7

Figure 2: Information Screen by Treatment Arm (English Translation)

3.4 Outcomes

We measure five pre-registered outcomes for each of the two parties. Every outcome is elicited once, after the information.[7] Two are stated: an indicator for intending to vote for the party, elicited after a turnout question and independently of it, and a feeling thermometer on the eleven-point scalometer of the German Longitudinal Election Study, the standard party-evaluation instrument of national election studies (Iyengar et al., 2019; Weisberg and Rusk, 1970) and a common measure in economics (Allcott et al., 2020; Boxell et al., 2024; Levy, 2021). Three are behavioral. The *newsletter opening* measure records whether the participant opens the party's newsletter subscription page. The *donation willingness* measure elicits, with the staircase method of Falk et al. (2018), the minimum compensation the participant requires to permit a real €5 donation to the party on their behalf; we reverse it so that higher values indicate greater willingness. The *campaign help* measure gives the participant a consequential choice

[7] A design that elicits an outcome both before and after the information invites consistency bias and stronger experimenter demand (Haaland et al., 2023, Section 3.1). We elicit beliefs about the CDU's position twice because the learning rate of Section 4.3 requires it, and every outcome once.

over how many of 1,000 participants in a future study will see each party's official campaign advertisement.[8] The pre-registered *support index* summarizes the five measures: each is standardized on the analysis sample and signed so that higher values indicate greater support, and the index is the standardized first principal component (Appendix Table A.3 reports the loadings; an equally weighted index gives the same picture, Appendix Table F.5).[9] Felt representation by the CDU on a 1–7 scale is one of four pre-registered mechanism questions, together with the expected CDU position in five years, expected vote shares, and expected coalitions. We also compute the perceived distance between the respondent's own position and the posterior CDU position, which was not pre-registered. The plan's eleventh outcome, the likelihood of abstaining, was elicited as the stated likelihood of voting and is analyzed as turnout likelihood in Appendix D.

3.5 Follow-Up

We conducted a pre-registered obfuscated follow-up approximately one week after the main survey, designed to appear unrelated to it as a check on experimenter demand, which re-elicited vote intentions, thermometers, and turnout likelihood. Because only 41 percent of participants provide a valid response, we treat it as secondary and report its design, attrition, sample rule, and results in Appendix H, with a summary in Section 5.7.

4 Empirical Strategy

We report three estimands. The reduced form (RF) is the causal effect of the randomized information. Two-stage least squares translates that effect into units of perceived CDU position, weighting individual responses by the strength of belief updating. Local least squares gives equal weight to voters who update toward the information.

[8] Participants are truthfully told that a randomly selected participant's allocation determines what respondents to a future survey see. The donation and campaign measures were elicited for the CDU and AfD only; the newsletter links were offered for all parties.

[9] The pre-analysis plan describes the two indexes as exploratory and does not specify their construction. We use the first principal component, with loadings estimated on the analysis sample of 5,040 respondents.

4.1 Reduced Form

As pre-registered, we treat the four-valued signal as continuous and estimate

$$y_i = \alpha + \beta \cdot \text{Liberal Signal}_i + \theta' X_i + \varepsilon_i, \tag{1}$$

where y_i is an outcome and Liberal Signal_i is the sign-reversed treatment value. The coefficient β is the causal effect of receiving a signal that portrays the CDU as one point more liberal. In every specification, pooled or within an attitude group, X_i contains age, gender, immigration background, East Germany, education categories, and indicators for the pre-treatment belief about the CDU's position. We use heteroskedasticity-robust (HC1) standard errors for the reduced form and 2SLS; LLS standard errors come from the Bayesian bootstrap described in Section 4.3. Throughout, "significant" means significant at the 5 percent level in a two-sided test; the tables mark the 10, 5, and 1 percent levels. Vote intentions are measured in percentage points; every other outcome is standardized on the analysis sample and measured in standard deviations. A saturated version with indicators for each arm finds no evidence against linearity in the signal for the posterior or for any vote outcome; across the 28 tests in Appendix Table C.3, the smallest p-value is .08.

4.2 Effects of Perceived Position: 2SLS

To estimate the causal effect of the perceived CDU position, we instrument the liberal-coded posterior with the liberal-coded signal.[10] The first stage is

$$\text{Liberal Posterior}_i = \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 \cdot \text{Liberal Signal}_i + \delta' X_i + \eta_i, \tag{2}$$

[10]The pre-analysis plan framed the instrumented analysis in terms of a gap measure, the absolute distance between the respondent's attitude and the position of the closest party other than the AfD. We use the perceived CDU position as the endogenous variable throughout because it is directly observed, maps one-to-one onto the randomized information, and avoids the compound construction of the gap, whose first stage changes sign across respondents on different sides of the CDU. Appendix Table F.4 reports the pre-registered gap specification under 2SLS for every outcome. The plan also committed to an adjusted effect based on Balla-Elliott (2026); we implement it as LLS for the perceived CDU position (Section 4.3). The same table reports LLS for the gap, on the respondents whose gap moves toward the signal-implied gap (955 in the full sample, 751 among conservative voters), but the estimator is not identified for this variable: the gap is constructed from the respondent's own pre-treatment attitude, so within a learning-rate window it varies with that attitude and not only with the signal, and the pre-treatment placebo test fails. We report these estimates because they were pre-registered and do not interpret them.

and the second stage replaces the signal in equation (1) with the fitted posterior. The coefficient is measured per one-unit more liberal perceived CDU position. The exclusion restriction requires that the signal affect outcomes only through beliefs about the CDU's position. Section 5.1 reports the checks: the signal leaves respondents' own attitudes, their beliefs about the other parties, and their expectations about vote shares and coalitions unchanged, with one exception, the perceived FDP position, which moves by one-sixth of the CDU first stage. Because the signal revises where respondents expect the CDU to stand both now and in five years, the 2SLS coefficient measures the response to a one-unit more liberal current perceived position together with the accompanying revision of the expected future position.[11] With a single instrument, the 2SLS coefficient is the reduced form divided by the first stage, and the Anderson–Rubin test of the 2SLS coefficient is the reduced-form test; Appendix Table F.3 reports Anderson–Rubin confidence sets, which are robust to weak instruments (Anderson and Rubin, 1949).

4.3 Effects of Perceived Position: LLS

Standard 2SLS identifies a causal average in which each voter is weighted by the strength of their belief updating (Angrist and Imbens, 1995; Imbens and Angrist, 1994). This weighting need not deliver a representative average: voters with precise priors update less even when the party's position matters more for their choices. Following Balla-Elliott (2026), we therefore complement 2SLS with LLS, an estimator developed for information-provision experiments that weights updaters equally. The estimator conditions on each respondent's observed learning rate,

$$\lambda_i = \frac{\text{posterior}_i - \text{prior}_i}{\text{signal}_i - \text{prior}_i},$$

and estimates the effect of the posterior within narrow windows of the learning-rate distribution, where posterior beliefs vary only through the randomized signal once the prior is held fixed.[12] The

[11] 2SLS also requires monotonicity: no respondent would have moved their belief in the opposite direction under a different signal. The 862 respondents who move away from the signal under their realized assignment do not contradict this assumption, and restricting the sample to respondents whose posterior is no farther from the signal than their prior gives similar estimates (Appendix Table F.1).

[12] This requires the learning rate to be an individual characteristic that does not depend on the signal received, an assumption stronger than the exclusion restriction of 2SLS. With beliefs reported on an integer scale, the learning rates a respondent can attain depend on the distance between prior and signal, which is one way the assumption can fail. Pre-treatment placebo tests of the assumption pass among conservative voters, the group on which our main

estimand is the equally weighted average response among positive updaters, that is, respondents whose learning rate is positive because their posterior moves from the prior in the direction of the signal. Three groups are excluded, as in Balla-Elliott (2026): respondents whose prior coincides with the signal, for whom the learning rate is undefined; non-updaters, for whom the posterior does not vary with the signal, so the local regression is not identified; and respondents who update away from the signal, whose behavior the learning model does not describe.[13]

We implement LLS with the companion R package of Balla-Elliott (2026), with 1,000 Bayesian-bootstrap draws for inference, at bandwidth $h = .075$ on the normalized ranks of the learning rate.[14] Within attitude groups, LLS controls for the CDU prior; in the pooled sample it adds the demographic controls of equation (1).[15] Appendix E gives the implementation details.

5 Results

5.1 First Stage and Exclusion Restriction Checks

The information moves beliefs about the CDU as intended. Figure 3 plots the mean posterior belief about the CDU's position by treatment arm, in the full sample and in each attitude group. Participants who receive a signal of 4 report a posterior of 4.7 on average; those who receive a signal of 7 report 6.2. The adjusted first stage of equation (2) is 0.497 posterior points per signal point (95 percent confidence interval 0.446 to 0.547), with a robust F-statistic of 375. The first stage is 0.50 among liberal, 0.55 among moderate, and 0.47 among conservative voters, and none of the pairwise differences approaches significance (Appendix Table C.1). The same average belief shift therefore reaches voters across the policy space, so differences in average

results rest, but not in the pooled sample or among liberal voters (Appendix Table E.4).

[13] Appendix Table E.5 reports RF and 2SLS estimates on the LLS sample for comparison.

[14] The bandwidth is the share of the learning-rate distribution that each local regression uses. We take the four values that Balla-Elliott (2026) examine for Roth et al. (2022) (their Table D.1), $h = .05, .075, .10$, and .15, and use the narrowest at which the LLS pre-treatment placebo tests pass among conservative voters, the population on which our LLS estimates rest. The rule errs against us: at $h = .05$ every conservative-group estimate is larger in magnitude. Appendix E reports every estimate at all four bandwidths.

[15] The pre-analysis plan's control set for the instrumented analysis includes the demographics, which every reduced-form and 2SLS specification and the pooled LLS retain. Within attitude groups we drop them because assignment is randomized within attitude strata, so they are precision controls rather than identifying ones, and because the subgroup local regressions run on windows of a few dozen respondents, which leave little room for additional regressors. Adding them changes no conclusion (Appendix Table E.2).

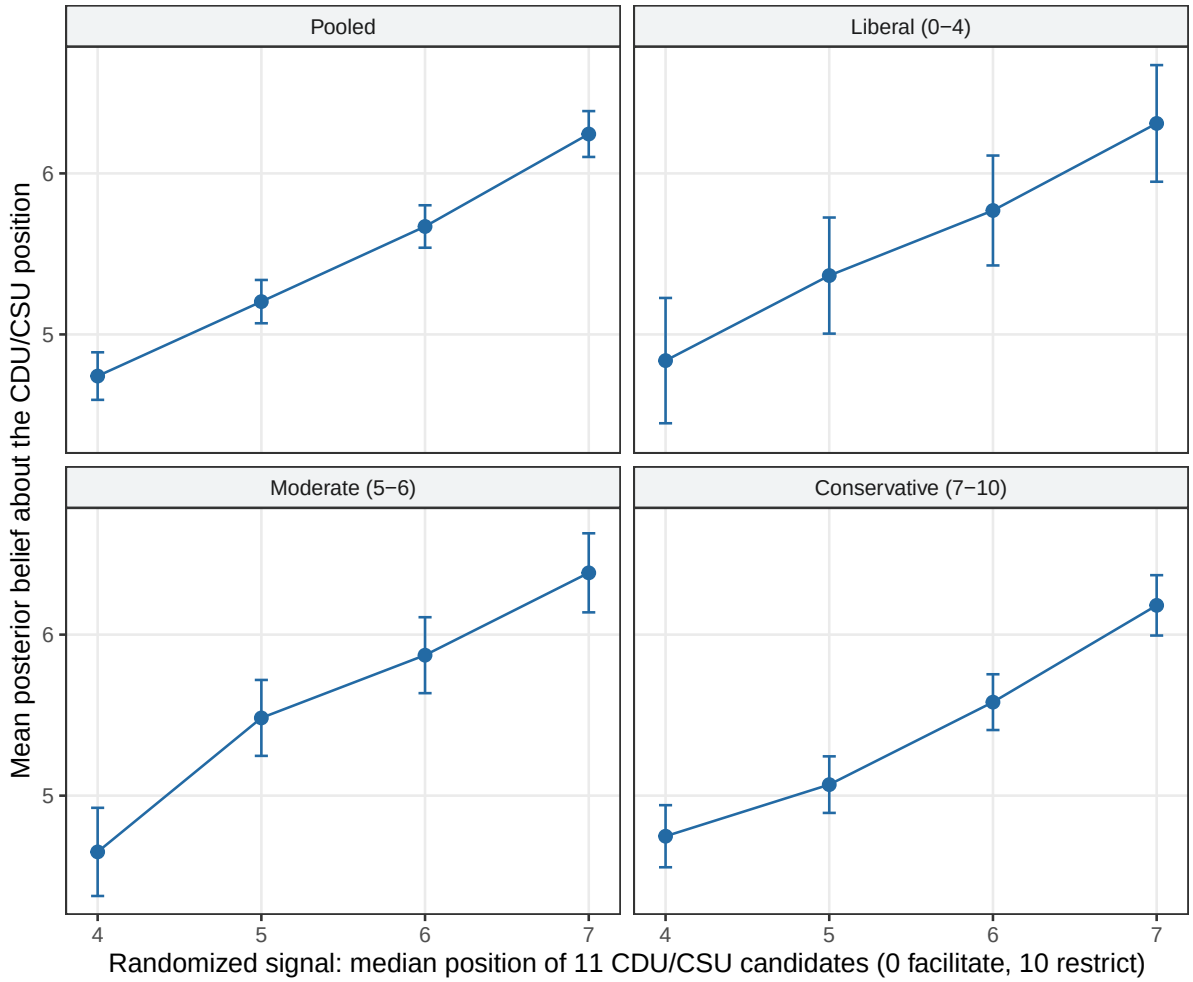


Figure 3: Belief Updating by Treatment Arm
Note: Mean post-treatment belief about the CDU/CSU immigration position by randomized signal, with 95 percent confidence intervals, in the full sample and in the three attitude groups. Positions run from 0 (strongly facilitate immigration) to 10 (strongly restrict immigration). Appendix Table C.1 reports the first-stage coefficients with controls, by population, and tests their equality across groups.

updating do not account for the heterogeneous political responses that follow. The pre-registered manipulation check agrees: the mean absolute distance between beliefs and the signal falls from 2.57 before treatment to 1.84 after it, and 2,370 of the 5,040 respondents reduce the absolute distance between their belief and the signal, 1,808 leave their belief unchanged, and 862 increase it.[16]

The exclusion restriction requires the signal to affect political outcomes only through the perceived CDU position. A central threat is cross-learning: respondents might update other beliefs at the same time (Haaland et al., 2023). Appendix Table C.2 reports these checks:

[16]The 2,654 positive updaters of Section 4.3 exceed the 2,370 who move closer because a respondent who overshoots the signal has a positive learning rate but need not end up closer to it.

the signal does not change respondents' own immigration attitude (0.001 points per signal point, $p = .99$), their perceived AfD position (−0.003, $p = .90$), the importance they attach to immigration (−0.018 points on the 1–5 scale, $p = .15$), their expected CDU and AfD vote shares, or their expected coalitions. The only other-party belief that moves is the perceived FDP position, by 0.08 points per signal point ($p = .02$), one-sixth of the CDU first stage. Respondents do revise where they expect the CDU to stand in five years, by 0.37 points per signal point, so they interpret the information as revealing a durable party position. Finally, the signal does not change the share of respondents who perceive the survey as politically biased ($p = .44$), which speaks against differential experimenter demand across arms.

5.2 Vote Intentions Across the Policy Space

A more liberal perceived CDU position raises AfD vote intention, and the gain comes from conservative voters. In the full sample, a one-point more liberal signal raises AfD vote intention by 1.1 percentage points (95 percent confidence interval 0.0 to 2.1), which is 2.1 points per unit of perceived CDU position under 2SLS. The pooled LLS estimate is 3.3 points (0.8 to 5.8), but LLS fails its pre-treatment placebo test in the pooled sample (Appendix Table E.4), so we rest the pooled estimates on the reduced form and 2SLS. CDU vote intention does not change significantly under any estimator. The pooled effect averages the group responses we turn to next; Appendix G reports the estimates by region. Figure 4 reports the effects by attitude group. Panel A shows the reduced form, in percentage points per one-point more liberal signal, and Panel B the 2SLS and LLS effects, in percentage points per one-point more liberal perceived CDU position. Appendix Tables D.1 to D.4 report every coefficient.

The response is concentrated where the spatial model predicts it: among conservative voters, a one-point more liberal signal raises AfD vote intention by 1.7 percentage points (0.2 to 3.1), which is 3.5 points per unit of perceived CDU position under 2SLS (0.5 to 6.5) and 4.8 points under LLS (1.5 to 8.1).[17] To put these magnitudes in perspective, 44 percent of

[17]The reduced-form estimate lies between 1.7 and 2.2 points, and is significant, under each pre-registered sample restriction and with the 87 speeders included (Appendix Tables F.1 and F.2), and the Anderson–Rubin confidence set for the 2SLS effect is bounded and excludes zero (Appendix Table F.3). The LLS estimate is 6.0 points at $h = .05$, 4.6 at .10, and 4.2 at .15, significant at each (Appendix Table E.1).

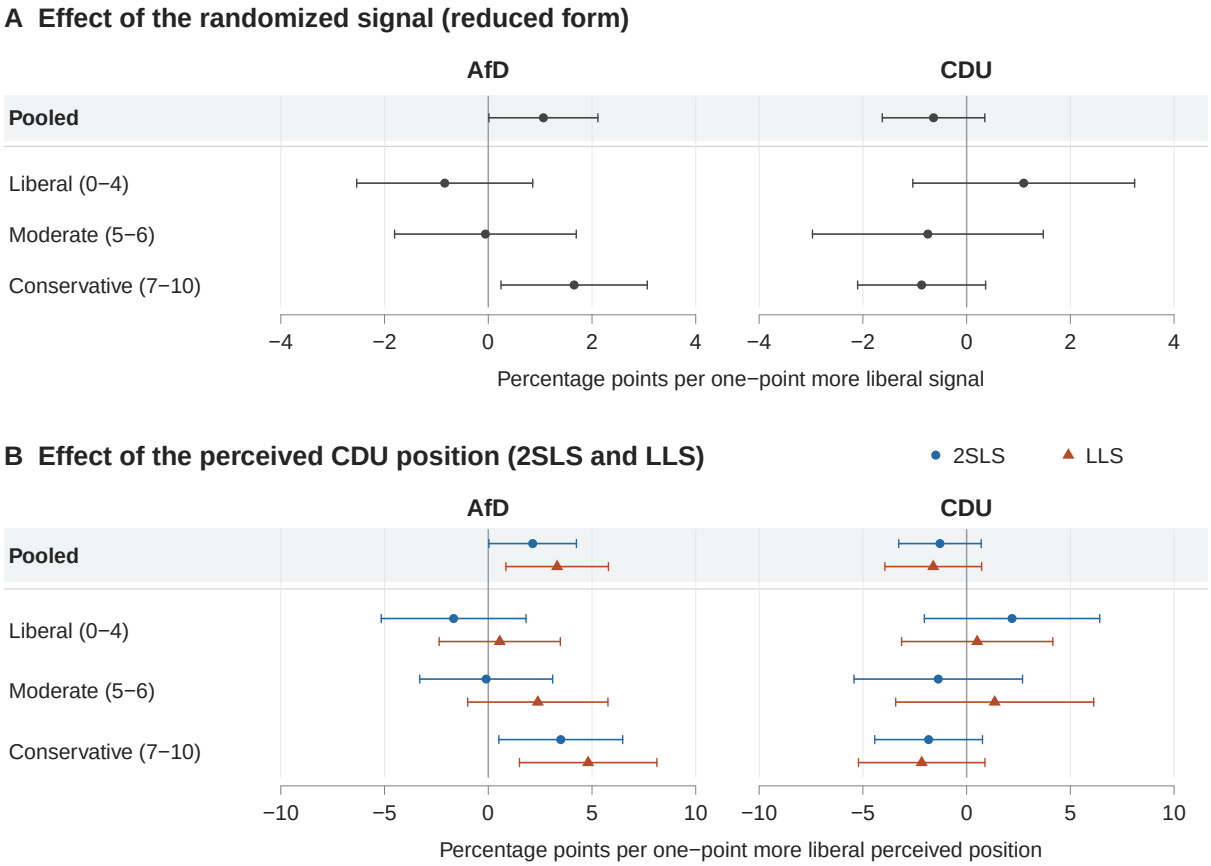


Figure 4: Effects on Vote Intentions

Note: Points are coefficient estimates and bars are 95 percent confidence intervals. Positive values mean that a more liberal CDU signal (Panel A) or perceived position (Panel B) raises the probability of intending to vote for the named party, in percentage points. Estimators, samples, and controls as in Section 4. Population sizes: 5,040, 823, 1,052, and 3,165 for RF and 2SLS; 2,654, 453, 579, and 1,622 positive updaters for LLS.

conservative respondents (1,376 of 3,165) intend to vote for the AfD. The observed range of candidate medians, from 4 to 7, spans three points, so moving the signal across that range changes AfD vote intention in this group by about 5 percentage points, or 11 percent of its baseline. The LLS estimate exceeds the 2SLS estimate, the pattern Balla-Elliott (2026) documents across information experiments.

Liberal and moderate voters show no significant movement toward the AfD. Their reduced-form effects are −0.8 ($p = .33$) and −0.1 percentage points ($p = .95$), and their LLS estimates 0.6 ($p = .71$) and 2.4 points ($p = .17$). The conservative-versus-liberal difference in the AfD vote response is 2.5 percentage points under the reduced form ($p = .027$), 5.2 points under 2SLS ($p = .027$), and 4.3 points under LLS ($p = .061$; Appendix Table D.7). The pattern does not depend on the three-group coarsening: across the eleven randomization strata, the

reduced-form effect on AfD vote intention increases by 0.34 percentage points for each one-point more conservative pre-treatment attitude (SE 0.16, $p = .036$), the gradient that single crossing implies for the utility difference and, under a linear voting rule, for vote intention (Appendix Figure D.1).[18]

The CDU side of the substitution is smaller and not significant. Among conservative voters, the CDU vote response is −0.9 percentage points under the reduced form ($p = .17$), −1.8 under 2SLS, and −2.2 under LLS ($p = .16$). The sign is the one spatial substitution implies, but every confidence interval includes zero. Because outcomes are elicited once, after the information (Section 3.4), the design identifies the effect of the perceived CDU position on each party's vote share and not the flows between parties. The effect on the sum of the two vote indicators is 0.8 points (SE 0.75) in the full group and 2.2 points (SE 0.91) in East Germany (Appendix Table G.2): there the AfD's gain exceeds the CDU's loss, and the difference is a loss for the other parties. Turnout likelihood does not respond under the design-based estimators (Appendix Table D.6), and among conservative voters no other party's vote intention moves by more than 0.4 points under the reduced form (Appendix Table D.5). Liberal voters, who evaluate the CDU more favorably (Section 5.3), show no significant change in vote intention either (+1.1 points, $p = .31$), so the pooled CDU response, negative and imprecise under every estimator, nets a conservative loss against a liberal gain that the sample cannot detect.

5.3 Party Evaluations and Overall Support

The evaluation measures reproduce the vote pattern with more precision and add the response that vote intentions do not show: liberal voters warm to the CDU. The gain in precision is expected: the thermometer registers a change in evaluation for every voter, whereas vote intention changes only for voters who switch parties. Figure 5 reports the effects on the feeling thermometers and on the pre-registered support indexes, in standard deviations. The thermometer gives the most precise evidence of the AfD gain. In the model the information leaves the AfD's own utility unchanged and moves only its attractiveness relative to the CDU, so the thermometer

[18] Moving the conservative-group cutoff to 6 or to 8 leaves the pattern intact, with larger effects in the more restrictive group (Appendix Table D.9).

response is what the model predicts if respondents rate parties relative to one another rather than on an absolute scale. Among conservative voters, a one-point more liberal signal raises the AfD thermometer by 0.040 standard deviations (0.011 to 0.069), which is 0.085 per unit of perceived position under 2SLS and 0.094 under LLS; in the full sample the reduced-form effect is 0.025 standard deviations ($p = .037$). The CDU thermometer among conservative voters falls under LLS (−0.074, $p = .029$) and is imprecise under the reduced form (−0.016, $p = .26$). The support indexes, which add the three behavioral measures to vote intention and the thermometer, move the same way. Among conservative voters, the AfD index rises by 0.026 standard deviations per signal point under the reduced form ($p = .07$), 0.056 under 2SLS, and 0.104 under LLS (0.034 to 0.174); the CDU index falls by 0.019 ($p = .21$), 0.040, and 0.091 (LLS, −0.163 to −0.019). Every estimator places the AfD response above zero and the CDU response below it, and the LLS estimates reach conventional significance on both sides.

Liberal voters respond on the CDU side. Their CDU thermometer rises by 0.058 standard deviations per signal point (0.008 to 0.109; 0.116 under 2SLS), while their AfD thermometer does not move (0.016, $p = .46$). Liberal voters thus respond to the same information in the opposite direction, as the spatial model predicts: they evaluate the CDU more favorably, while conservative voters evaluate the AfD more favorably and the CDU less.[19] Moderate voters show no significant response on any evaluation measure, and neither liberal nor moderate voters show an index response. An equally weighted index in the style of Kling et al. (2007) gives the same picture (Appendix Table F.5). Turnout likelihood, the plan's eleventh outcome, does not respond in any population under the reduced form or 2SLS (Appendix Table D.6).

Taken together, the vote and evaluation results decide which of the two accounts of Section 2.3 dominates. Legitimation predicts that a CDU signal one point closer to the AfD raises AfD support among conservative voters. Spatial substitution predicts that it lowers AfD support and raises CDU support in that group. The data give the second pattern: read in the conservative direction, the signal lowers AfD vote intention by 1.7 percentage points and the AfD thermometer by 0.040 standard deviations among conservative voters, and the CDU response has the opposite sign under every estimator, rising on the thermometer under LLS. Liberal

[19] LLS gives 0.033 ($p = .53$) for the liberal CDU response and fails its pre-treatment placebo test in this group (Appendix Table E.4), so we rest the result on the reduced form.

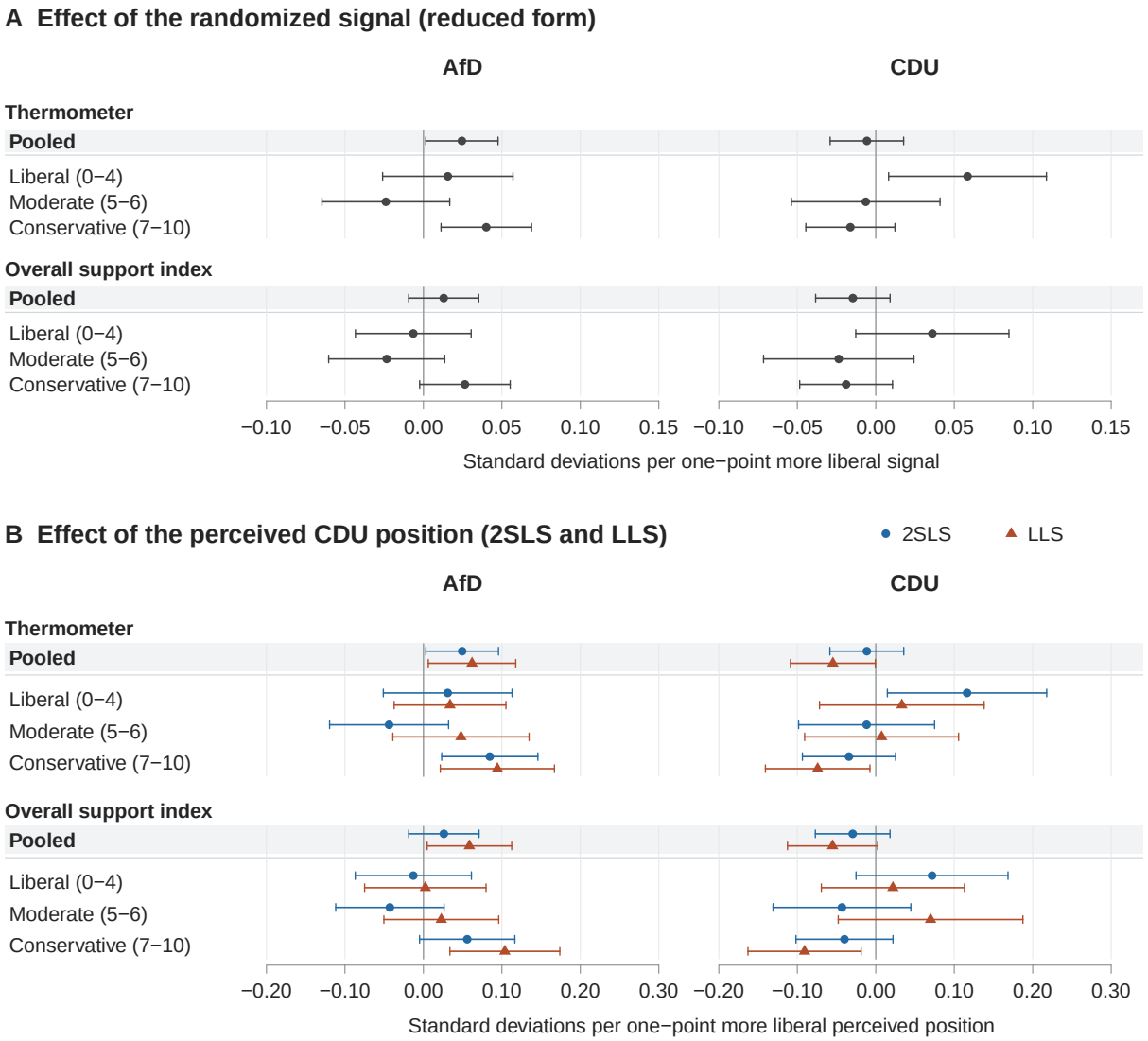


Figure 5: Effects on Party Evaluations and Overall Support
Note: Points are coefficient estimates and bars are 95 percent confidence intervals, in standard deviations of the outcome. The overall support index is the standardized first principal component of vote intention, the thermometer, newsletter opening, donation willingness, and campaign help, signed so that higher values indicate greater support for the named party. Estimators, samples, and controls as in Figure 4.

voters warm to the CDU without a significant change in their vote, and moderate voters show no significant response, as the spatial account predicts and legitimation does not address. Protest voting, under which a marginal change in a mainstream party's perceived position should not move far-right support at all, let alone in a way that varies with the voter's own position, finds no support either. Within the positional channel, spatial substitution dominates legitimation, and generalized discontent plays no detectable part.

5.4 Behavioral Measures

The behavioral measures move in the direction of substitution only under LLS. Figure 6 reports the three measures separately. Under LLS, conservative voters move on two margins. They shift campaign help away from the CDU, by −0.104 standard deviations per unit of perceived position ($p = .007$), and, less precisely, toward the AfD (0.075, $p = .044$), and they open the AfD newsletter page more often (0.086, $p = .025$); the donation margins do not respond significantly. On the LLS sample, the reduced-form CDU campaign-help effect is −0.030 per signal point ($p = .20$) and the 2SLS effect −0.041, of the same sign and imprecise (Appendix Table E.5). In the full conservative group, none of the six behavioral coefficients under the reduced form or 2SLS is distinguishable from zero; the reduced-form confidence intervals include zero and effects nearly the size of the 0.040 thermometer response: their bounds farther from zero lie between 0.035 and 0.047 standard deviations in absolute value. Behavioral responses to information are typically smaller and noisier than stated responses (Haaland et al., 2023; Hill, 2020), and newsletter opening is a rare event, 5 percent of respondents (249 of 5,040) for the AfD page and 3 percent (166) for the CDU page.

5.5 Heterogeneity

Our design allows us to investigate four additional heterogeneity dimensions: region, the importance attached to immigration, the stated primary voting motive, and the delegate-versus-trustee view of representation. The first three point the same way: the AfD response is larger in East Germany, among respondents who rate immigration as important, and among those who vote on representation, although only the regional difference is significant at conventional levels (Appendix G). In East Germany, where 68 percent of respondents (2,073 of 3,037) hold conservative attitudes, a one-point more liberal signal raises AfD vote intention by 1.9 percentage points ($p = .010$); in the West the effect is −0.3, and the difference of 2.2 points is significant under the reduced form and 2SLS ($p = .034$ and .026; Appendix Table G.1). Among the 3,615 respondents who rate immigration as important, the reduced-form effect is 1.6 points ($p = .014$) against 0.2 among the other 1,425; the difference is within sampling error under the reduced form and 2SLS. Among the 2,728 respondents who say they vote for the party that best represents their

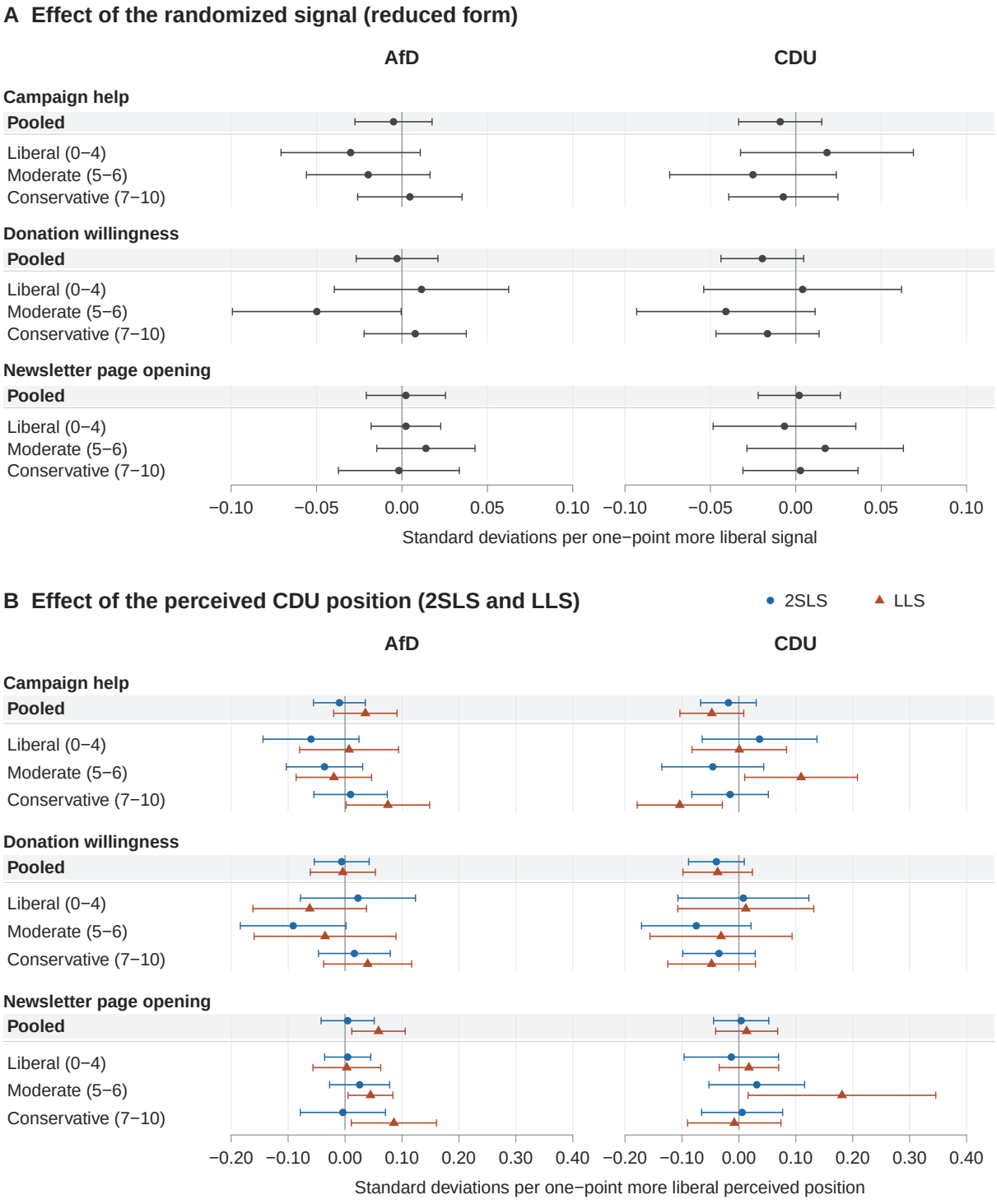


Figure 6: Effects on the Behavioral Measures
Note: Points are coefficient estimates and bars are 95 percent confidence intervals, in standard deviations. Higher values indicate greater support for the named party: more campaign advertisements allocated to the party, lower compensation demanded to permit a donation, and opening the party's newsletter page. Estimators, samples, and controls as in Figure 4.

opinions, the effect is 2.1 points ($p = .003$) against 0.0 among the other 2,308, a difference of 2.0 points under the reduced form ($p = .062$) and 4.0 under 2SLS ($p = .071$). Respondents who

think a member of parliament should follow the voters' opinion respond like those who think members should follow their own: 0.7 against 1.4 points, a difference within sampling error ($p = .47$). Immigration importance and the view of representation are elicited after treatment, so these two splits are descriptive (Appendix Table G.3).

5.6 Mechanism: Perceived Distance and Felt Representation

The spatial account operates through representation: moving a party changes which voters see it as speaking for them. Figure 7 reports the reduced-form effects of the signal on perceived distance to the CDU and on felt representation by the CDU. A signal portraying the CDU as one point more liberal reduces perceived distance by 0.52 points among liberal voters and raises it by 0.48 points among conservative voters; the two effects are precisely estimated and the moderate-group effect is within sampling error (0.016 points, SE 0.036). For voters on either side of the CDU the distance response restates the first stage, since the signal moves the perceived CDU position toward liberal voters and away from conservative ones; felt representation is the substantive result. Felt representation moves in the corresponding directions: it rises by 0.145 points on the 1–7 scale among liberal voters (SE 0.048, $p = .003$) and falls by 0.078 points among conservative voters (SE 0.025, $p = .002$). In the pooled sample the two responses largely offset: the pooled effect is −0.033 points ($p = .12$), not statistically significant. The representation property of Section 2.2 allows this offset, and the pooled estimate conceals a mechanism that operates on both sides of the policy space.

The intervention changes one input into political evaluations, the perceived position of one party on one issue, and moves the broad felt-representation measure by a fraction of a scale point. That this narrow change produces measurable movements in electoral support indicates how consequential a representation gap can be when it separates voters from their closest mainstream option.

5.7 Follow-Up

The pre-registered obfuscated follow-up re-elicited vote intentions, a thermometer on a different scale, and turnout likelihood from 2,047 of the 5,040 participants about one week after the

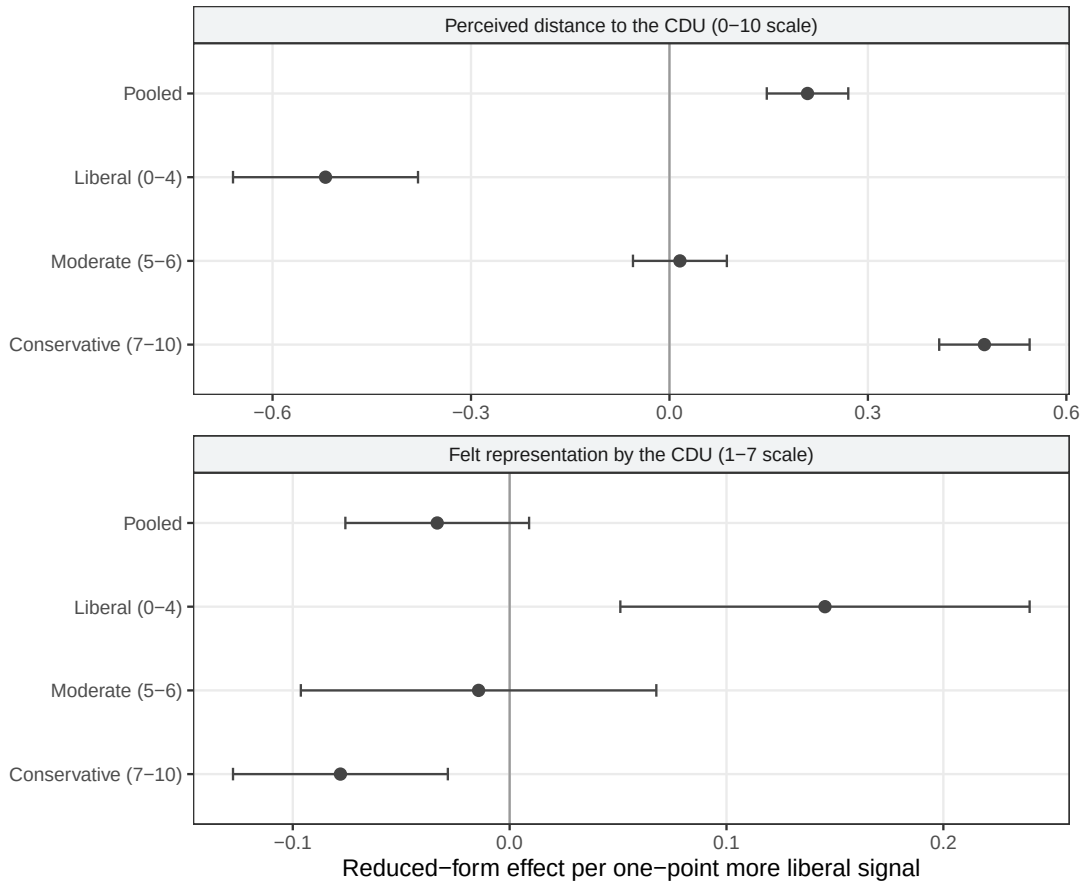


Figure 7: Effects on Perceived Distance and Felt Representation
Note: Reduced-form effects of a one-point more liberal signal on the perceived distance between the respondent's own position and the CDU's position (top) and on felt representation by the CDU, "How well does the CDU represent people like you?" on a 1–7 scale (bottom). Full nonspeeder samples, controls of equation (1), robust standard errors, 95 percent confidence intervals.

main survey (Appendix H). Response is unrelated to treatment assignment (joint $p = .75$) but selective: respondents are younger and more often from West Germany (Appendix Table H.1). The follow-up is too imprecise to serve its pre-registered purpose, a check on experimenter demand, or to speak to persistence. Among the 1,243 conservative voters who responded, the main-survey AfD vote effect is itself 1.1 percentage points under the reduced form, with a standard error of the same size, and −0.6 under LLS (SE 2.3), against 1.7 and 4.8 in the full group.[20] The follow-up estimates in this group are 0.1 points (−2.2 to 2.3) and −0.9 (−5.6 to 3.8), and the within-person changes between waves are −1.1 points ($p = .11$) and −0.3 ($p = .80$;

[20]Under LLS, the main-survey effect is concentrated among the voters who did not respond: 7.5 points (SE 2.2) among the 1,922 conservative nonrespondents against −0.6 among respondents, $p = .013$ for the difference, and the gap is as large within East Germany, 8.0 against 0.6 ($p = .07$), so regional composition does not account for it. Under the reduced form the difference is within sampling error: 2.0 points among nonrespondents against 1.1 ($p = .54$).

Appendix Tables H.2 and H.4). No follow-up estimate for the AfD or the CDU is significant at the 5 percent level in the full sample or in any attitude group under any estimator, with or without inverse-response weights (Appendix Table H.3).[21] We therefore read the main estimates as the short-run electoral response to perceived positioning during an active campaign and draw no conclusion about persistence in either direction.

6 Discussion and Conclusion

The experiment isolates one component of party repositioning, the perceived policy position, and holds fixed everything that accompanies real movements: rhetoric, salience, coalition signals, credibility, and media coverage. Within that channel, the evidence is clear about who responds. Voters with conservative immigration attitudes, a majority of the German electorate, move toward the far right when the mainstream right is perceived as more liberal, and the same information makes them feel less represented by it. Voters with liberal attitudes feel better represented and warm to the mainstream right, but their vote does not change detectably. The pooled vote estimate is smaller than the conservative-group estimate because it averages that response with the null responses of moderate and liberal voters; on felt representation, where the two sides move in opposite directions, the pooled estimate is within sampling error. The returns to a mainstream party's position on immigration are therefore not a fixed parameter: they depend on where the party stands relative to the voters it faces and on how those voters are distributed.

The magnitudes are large relative to the intervention. A one-point difference in a reported candidate median, a modest and truthful piece of information, changes AfD vote intention among conservative voters by 1.7 percentage points, and the three-point range of candidate medians in the data changes it by 5 percentage points, 11 percent of the group's baseline. For comparison, Castanho Silva and Wratil (2023) find no effect of learning that some party represents one's views on general populist attitudes. This suggests that what matters is the object manipulated:

[21] The follow-up also re-elicited vote intentions and thermometers for the other parties. Two of the LLS estimates among liberal voters, where the follow-up LLS aggregates over 128 respondents, are significant at the 5 percent level: a one-point more liberal perceived CDU position lowers SPD vote intention by 10.4 percentage points (SE 3.9) and raises other-party vote intention by 10.2 points (SE 4.2). A swap between two non-CDU options is not what the spatial account predicts for these voters, whose CDU vote intention moves by 2.4 points (SE 1.7); the reduced-form estimates have the same signs and are not significant at the 5 percent level.

not an abstract sense of representation, but the perceived position of the specific mainstream party that competes with the far right on the issue voters care about, in the weeks before an election.

How much of the AfD's rise can the positional channel account for? Figure 1 supplies the ingredients. Between the 2014 wave of the GLES tracking survey and the peak of the refugee crisis in August 2016, the perceived CDU position on the same 0–10 item moved from 6.9 to 5.8, 1.1 points in the liberal direction, and the AfD's vote-intention share rose from 8 to 13 percent. The shift lies within the range of perceived positions the experiment induces, so the positional channel operated at a scale the experiment covers. Our estimates do not support a national accounting, however: the response is concentrated in East Germany, which our sample over-represents, and reweighted to the national population shares the pooled effect is imprecise.[22] Two caveats apply even to this reading: the estimates are short-run responses measured in 2025 and applied to 2015, and the perceived movement of 2015 arrived with the refugee inflow, the salience, and the coverage that the experiment holds fixed. Within those limits, the positional channel is large enough to matter where the far right is a viable choice; the data do not say how much of the national rise it produced.

Three features of the setting bound the interpretation. First, the response is concentrated in East Germany, where AfD support is larger: among conservative voters, the AfD vote effect is 2.5 percentage points in the East and −0.1 in the West, and the West estimate's confidence interval includes both zero and the 1.7-point conservative-group effect (Appendix Table G.2). The estimates speak to electorates in which the far right is a viable choice, which is also where its gains have been largest. Second, the estimates are short-run responses during an active campaign, and the follow-up is too imprecise to say whether they persist. Third, the evidence that the response extends to behavior rests on two margins, campaign help and the AfD newsletter page, and on LLS; under the design-based estimators the behavioral measures are imprecise.

For the debate over whether mainstream parties should accommodate or distance themselves

[22] Perceived positions and vote-intention shares are the weighted wave means behind Figure 1. Applied to the 1.1-point shift, the pooled 2SLS estimate of Section 5.2 implies an increase in AfD vote intention of 2.4 percentage points, 45 percent of the rise. With the East and West estimates of Appendix Table G.1 weighted by the regions' national population shares, as in Appendix Figure A.2, the 2SLS effect is 0.30 points per unit of perceived position (SE 1.16), which implies 0.3 points, with a 95 percent confidence interval from −2.2 to 2.9 points.

from the radical right, the results reframe the question. A mainstream party perceived as moving toward the center does not simply gain or lose; it buys the goodwill of the voters it moves toward and pushes those it leaves unrepresented toward the far right, and the terms of that trade depend on the preference distribution. In an electorate where most voters stand to the right of the mainstream right on immigration, as in Germany, the trade runs in favor of the far right.

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A Sample and Measurement

A.1 Balance

Table A.1: Balance of Pre-Treatment Characteristics Across Signals

	Mean by randomized signal				
Pre-treatment variable	4	5	6	7	Joint p
Age	47.68	46.83	48.17	47.39	.162
Male	0.53	0.55	0.53	0.54	.622
Immigration background	0.13	0.14	0.13	0.12	.562
East Germany	0.60	0.60	0.61	0.59	.807
Own immigration attitude	7.09	7.12	7.22	6.98	.169
Prior CDU position	5.90	5.68	5.81	5.87	.230
Prior AfD position	8.82	8.88	8.85	8.79	.812
Prior SPD position	3.60	3.54	3.60	3.59	.894
Prior Greens position	2.59	2.54	2.59	2.58	.958
Prior FDP position	5.34	5.21	5.44	5.36	.233
Prior Left position	4.81	4.71	4.79	4.89	.418
Education category College degree	0.31	0.31	0.27	0.30	.107
Education category No college	0.62	0.59	0.64	0.60	.109
Education category Some college	0.07	0.09	0.09	0.10	.062
N	1,249	1,232	1,295	1,264	

Notes: Means by randomized signal and the p-value of a joint HC1 test that the three signal indicators have zero coefficients in a regression of the variable on arm indicators. Prior positions are pre-treatment beliefs about party positions on the 0–10 scale. The smallest joint p-value across the eleven variables and the education categories is .06.

A.2 Survey flow and the configuration of voters and parties

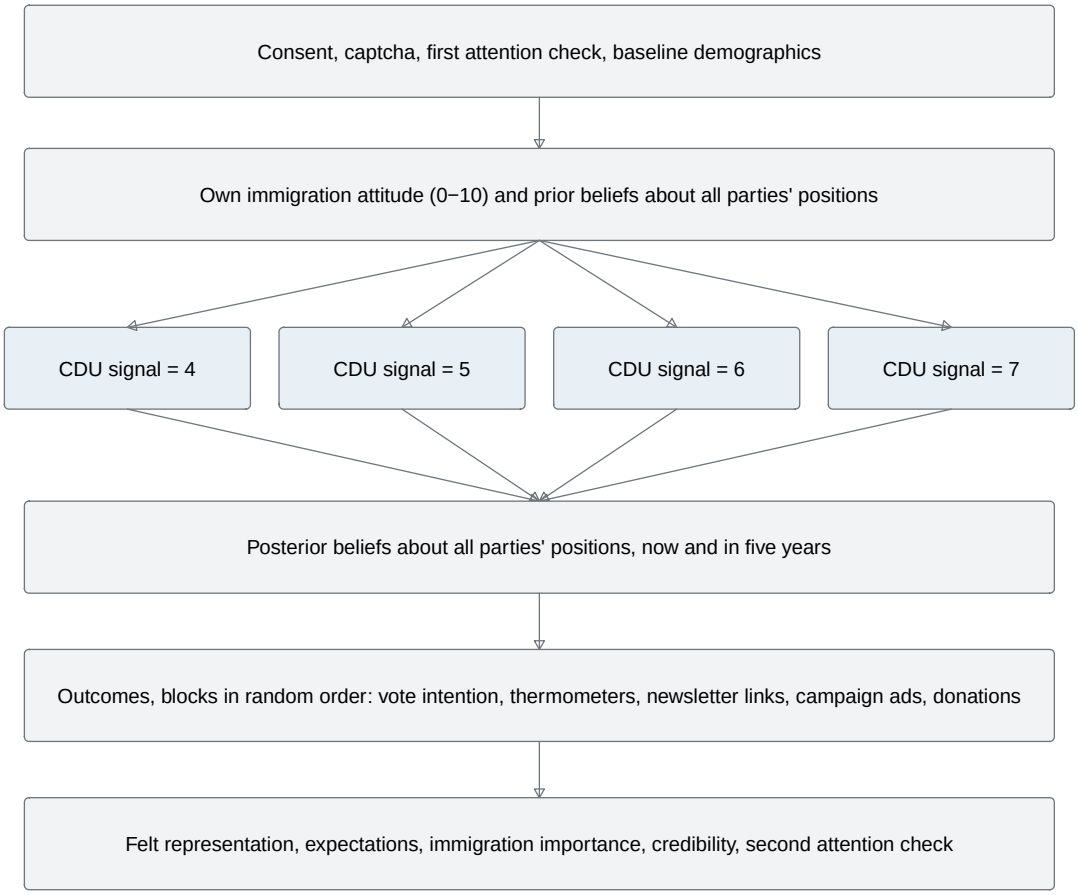


Figure A.1: Survey Sequence
Note: Participants who fail the captcha or the first attention check contribute no data. The signal is randomized within each of the eleven values of the own-attitude question.

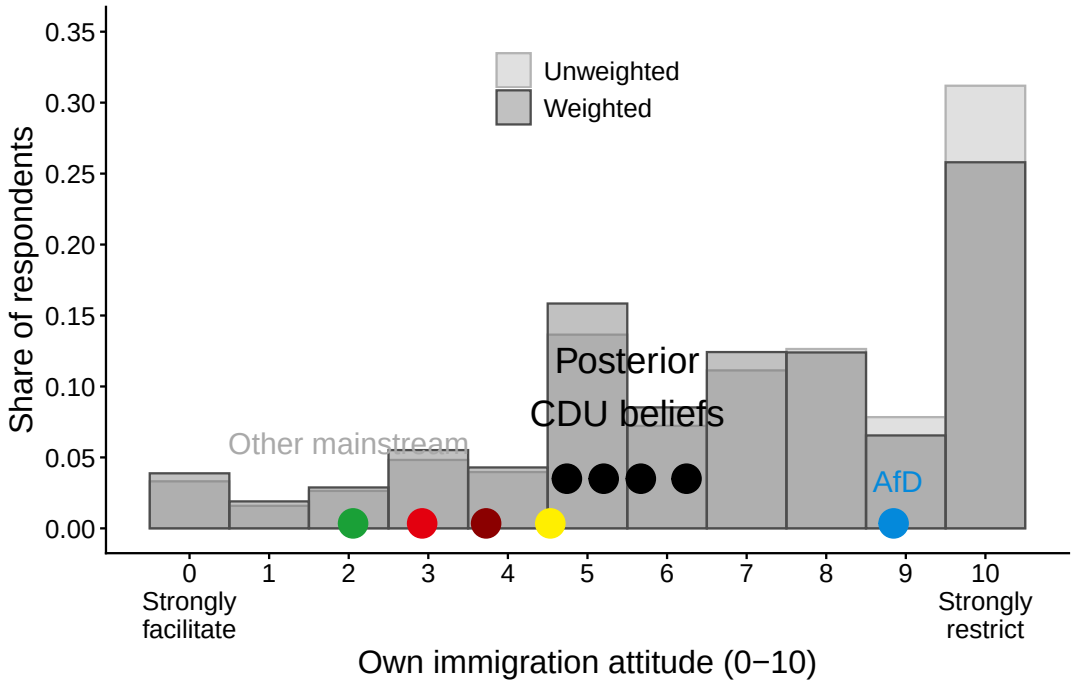


Figure A.2: Immigration Attitudes and Perceived Party Positions

Note: Bars show the distribution of respondents' own immigration attitudes, unweighted and reweighted to the national East–West population shares. Black circles show the mean post-treatment belief about the CDU's position by treatment arm; colored circles show the mean post-treatment beliefs about the other parties, pooling arms.

A.3 Outcome construction

Table A.2: Outcome Measures

Measure	Definition	Units in exhibits
Vote intention	Indicator for naming the party when asked which party one would vote for.	Percentage points
Thermometer	Feeling toward the party on an eleven-point scale from −5 to +5, standardized.	SD
Campaign help	Number of 1,000 future participants allocated to the party's official campaign advertisement, standardized.	SD
Donation willingness	205 minus the minimum compensation (in euros) demanded to permit a €5 donation to the party, elicited by a four- or five-step staircase, standardized.	SD
Newsletter opening	Indicator for opening the party's newsletter subscription page, standardized. Completed subscriptions are not observed.	SD
Support index	Standardized first principal component of the five measures above, each standardized and signed toward support.	SD
Felt representation	"How well does the CDU represent people like you?"	1–7 scale
Perceived distance	Absolute difference between the own attitude and the posterior belief about the CDU's position.	0–10 scale
Turnout likelihood	Stated likelihood of voting in the federal election, standardized.	SD

Table A.3: Loadings of the Support Indexes

Component (standardized, signed toward support)	AfD index	CDU index
Newsletter-page opening	0.221	0.229
Campaign help	0.494	0.499
Donation willingness	0.392	0.349
Thermometer	0.533	0.543
Vote intention	0.519	0.530
Share of variance, first component	0.573	0.469

Notes: First-principal-component loadings on the five support-signed measures, each standardized on the analysis sample, with loadings estimated on the 5,040 respondents of that sample.

B Formal Spatial Predictions

Section 2.2 derives, for a voter choosing between the CDU and the AfD, $\partial\Delta_i/\partial\ell_i = 2(x_i - m_i)$: the effect of a more liberal perceived CDU position on the AfD–CDU utility difference is monotone in the voter's own position and changes sign at $x_i = m_i$, which is the single-crossing property. Any smooth voting rule $P_i(A) = G(\Delta_i)$ with $G' > 0$ preserves it:

$$\frac{\partial P_i(A)}{\partial \ell_i} = G'(\Delta_i)\, 2(x_i - m_i).$$

The quadratic loss is not needed: if voter i evaluates party p by $V_i(p) = -L(x_i - \pi_p) + v_p$, with L differentiable, strictly convex and minimized at zero, then $\partial\Delta_i/\partial\ell_i = L'(x_i - m_i)$, which is zero at $x_i = m_i$ because L is minimized there and increases in x_i because L is convex, so the single-crossing property holds and $\partial P_i(A)/\partial\ell_i = G'(\Delta_i)\, L'(x_i - m_i)$. The sign change at $x_i = m_i$ holds for any such G; the monotone gradient in x_i holds when G is linear, as in a linear probability model, and need not otherwise, since $G'(\Delta_i)$ can fall as a voter moves away from the indifference margin. The population effect is the integral of these individual derivatives over the distribution of voter positions, which is the aggregation property: it can be small when group effects are large and of opposite sign, and it depends on the distribution. If felt representation is $R_i = r(|x_i - m_i|)$ with $r' < 0$, its response to ℓ_i also changes sign at $x_i = m_i$, which is the representation property. The vote-probability prediction requires that the CDU–AfD margin be the relevant one for voters to the CDU's right; for voters whose relevant alternative is another party or abstention, the same shift still lowers CDU support without a prediction for the AfD. Equal average first-stage updating across groups is not a prediction of the model but the condition under which differences in average updating do not account for heterogeneous political responses.

C Belief Updating and Exclusion Checks

Table C.1: First Stage by Population

Population	First stage	SE	95% CI	Robust F	N
Pooled	0.497	0.026	[0.446, 0.547]	375	5,040
Liberal (0–4)	0.503	0.068	[0.369, 0.637]	54	823
Moderate (5–6)	0.547	0.051	[0.447, 0.647]	115	1,052
Conservative (7–10)	0.474	0.033	[0.410, 0.538]	210	3,165
Differences between populations (coefficient, SE, p in last column)					
Liberal (0–4) minus Moderate (5–6)	-0.044	0.085			.602
Liberal (0–4) minus Conservative (7–10)	0.029	0.076			.701
Moderate (5–6) minus Conservative (7–10)	0.073	0.061			.225

Notes: Coefficient of the liberal-coded signal in a regression of the liberal-coded posterior belief about the CDU's position on the signal and the controls of equation (1), robust standard errors. The robust F is the squared t-statistic of the excluded instrument. The lower panel tests the equality of the first stage across populations.

Table C.2: Effects of the Signal on Other Beliefs, Attitudes, and Expectations

Outcome (original units)	RF coefficient	SE	p
Own immigration attitude, post-treatment (0–10)	0.001	0.035	.987
Perceived AfD position (0–10)	-0.003	0.025	.896
Perceived SPD position (0–10)	-0.041	0.026	.114
Perceived Greens position (0–10)	-0.005	0.028	.870
Perceived FDP position (0–10)	-0.079	0.035	.023
Perceived Left position (0–10)	-0.024	0.029	.406
Perceived CDU position in five years (0–10)	-0.373	0.028	<.001
Expected CDU vote share (percent)	-0.173	0.191	.366
Expected AfD vote share (percent)	0.320	0.270	.236
Expected CDU–AfD coalition (probability)	0.019	0.025	.438
Expected CDU–SPD coalition (probability)	0.000	0.023	.993
Expected CDU–Greens coalition (probability)	0.007	0.022	.763
Stated importance of immigration	-0.018	0.012	.153
Perceives the survey as politically biased (0/1)	-0.004	0.005	.441
N	5,040		

Notes: Reduced-form effects of a one-point more liberal signal on each outcome in its original units, full nonspeeder sample, controls of equation (1), robust standard errors. Perceived positions are post-treatment beliefs on the raw 0–10 scale, so a negative coefficient means a more liberal perceived position.

Table C.3: Tests of Linearity in the Signal

Outcome	Pooled	Liberal (0–4)	Moderate (5–6)	Conservative (7–10)
Posterior CDU position	.313	.169	.518	.646
AfD vote intention	.491	.282	.132	.796
CDU vote intention	.977	.137	.165	.883
AfD thermometer	.936	.440	.413	.899
CDU thermometer	.751	.937	.081	.794
AfD support index	.878	.242	.749	.871
CDU support index	.811	.391	.090	.342

Notes: p-values of joint HC1 tests that the deviations of the two intermediate arms (signals 5 and 6) from the linear signal effect are zero, in regressions that add indicators for these arms to equation (1).

D Complete Estimates and Heterogeneity

Tables D.1 to D.4 report every baseline coefficient for the six party-support outcomes, both parties, and the three estimators, one table per population. Table D.6 reports turnout likelihood. Table D.7 tests the differences between attitude groups, Table D.8 and Figure D.1 replace the grouping with the eleven exact attitude values, and Table D.9 moves the conservative-group cutoff.

Table D.1: Complete Estimates: Full Sample

	AfD			CDU		
Outcome	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS
Vote intention (pp)	1.06	2.14	3.32	-0.64	-1.28	-1.61
	(0.54)	(1.08)	(1.26)	(0.50)	(1.01)	(1.19)
	$p = 0.047$	$p = 0.047$	$p = 0.008$	$p = 0.206$	$p = 0.206$	$p = 0.177$
Thermometer (SD)	0.025	0.049	0.062	-0.006	-0.011	-0.055
	(0.012)	(0.024)	(0.028)	(0.012)	(0.024)	(0.028)
	$p = 0.037$	$p = 0.037$	$p = 0.029$	$p = 0.636$	$p = 0.635$	$p = 0.048$
Support index (SD)	0.013	0.026	0.059	-0.015	-0.029	-0.055
	(0.011)	(0.023)	(0.027)	(0.012)	(0.024)	(0.029)
	$p = 0.257$	$p = 0.255$	$p = 0.033$	$p = 0.228$	$p = 0.226$	$p = 0.060$
Campaign help (SD)	-0.005	-0.010	0.036	-0.009	-0.018	-0.047
	(0.012)	(0.023)	(0.028)	(0.012)	(0.025)	(0.029)
	$p = 0.667$	$p = 0.668$	$p = 0.208$	$p = 0.463$	$p = 0.461$	$p = 0.097$
Donation willingness (SD)	-0.003	-0.006	-0.004	-0.020	-0.039	-0.037
	(0.012)	(0.025)	(0.029)	(0.012)	(0.025)	(0.031)
	$p = 0.812$	$p = 0.813$	$p = 0.893$	$p = 0.113$	$p = 0.114$	$p = 0.231$
Newsletter opening (SD)	0.002	0.005	0.059	0.002	0.004	0.014
	(0.012)	(0.024)	(0.024)	(0.012)	(0.025)	(0.028)
	$p = 0.847$	$p = 0.847$	$p = 0.014$	$p = 0.870$	$p = 0.871$	$p = 0.623$
N	5,040	5,040	2,654	5,040	5,040	2,654
LLS aggregation *N*	—	—	2,570	—	—	2,570

Notes: Each cell reports the coefficient, its standard error in parentheses (robust for RF and 2SLS, Bayesian bootstrap for LLS), and the two-sided p-value. Vote effects are in percentage points; other outcomes in standard deviations, signed toward support. RF effects are per one-point more liberal signal; 2SLS and LLS effects per one-point more liberal perceived CDU position. RF and 2SLS: nonspeeders, controls of equation (1).

Table D.2: Complete Estimates: Liberal Voters (Attitude 0–4)

	AfD			CDU		
Outcome	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS
Vote intention (pp)	-0.84 (0.87) $p = 0.332$	-1.67 (1.78) $p = 0.348$	0.55 (1.49) $p = 0.711$	1.10 (1.09) $p = 0.313$	2.19 (2.16) $p = 0.310$	0.51 (1.86) $p = 0.784$
Thermometer (SD)	0.016 (0.021) $p = 0.464$	0.031 (0.042) $p = 0.460$	0.034 (0.036) $p = 0.351$	0.058 (0.026) $p = 0.023$	0.116 (0.052) $p = 0.025$	0.033 (0.054) $p = 0.535$
Support index (SD)	-0.006 (0.019) $p = 0.731$	-0.013 (0.038) $p = 0.734$	0.002 (0.039) $p = 0.951$	0.036 (0.025) $p = 0.148$	0.072 (0.049) $p = 0.147$	0.022 (0.046) $p = 0.639$
Campaign help (SD)	-0.030 (0.021) $p = 0.149$	-0.060 (0.043) $p = 0.165$	0.007 (0.044) $p = 0.873$	0.018 (0.026) $p = 0.479$	0.036 (0.051) $p = 0.480$	0.001 (0.042) $p = 0.986$
Donation willingness (SD)	0.011 (0.026) $p = 0.661$	0.023 (0.052) $p = 0.659$	-0.062 (0.051) $p = 0.222$	0.004 (0.030) $p = 0.892$	0.008 (0.059) $p = 0.892$	0.012 (0.061) $p = 0.842$
Newsletter opening (SD)	0.002 (0.010) $p = 0.824$	0.005 (0.021) $p = 0.824$	0.003 (0.030) $p = 0.918$	-0.007 (0.021) $p = 0.756$	-0.013 (0.042) $p = 0.756$	0.018 (0.027) $p = 0.507$
N	823	823	453	823	823	453
LLS aggregation *N*	—	—	436	—	—	436

Notes: As in Table D.1.

Table D.3: Complete Estimates: Moderate Voters (Attitude 5–6)

	AfD			CDU		
Outcome	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS
Vote intention (pp)	-0.06 (0.89) $p = 0.951$	-0.10 (1.63) $p = 0.951$	2.39 (1.72) $p = 0.166$	-0.75 (1.14) $p = 0.510$	-1.37 (2.07) $p = 0.510$	1.35 (2.43) $p = 0.578$
Thermometer (SD)	-0.024 (0.021) $p = 0.249$	-0.044 (0.039) $p = 0.258$	0.048 (0.044) $p = 0.280$	-0.006 (0.024) $p = 0.792$	-0.012 (0.044) $p = 0.792$	0.007 (0.050) $p = 0.881$
Support index (SD)	-0.023 (0.019) $p = 0.215$	-0.043 (0.035) $p = 0.225$	0.023 (0.037) $p = 0.542$	-0.024 (0.024) $p = 0.335$	-0.043 (0.045) $p = 0.336$	0.070 (0.060) $p = 0.245$
Campaign help (SD)	-0.020 (0.018) $p = 0.284$	-0.036 (0.034) $p = 0.292$	-0.020 (0.034) $p = 0.560$	-0.025 (0.025) $p = 0.314$	-0.046 (0.046) $p = 0.316$	0.109 (0.051) $p = 0.031$
Donation willingness (SD)	-0.050 (0.025) $p = 0.048$	-0.091 (0.047) $p = 0.055$	-0.035 (0.064) $p = 0.580$	-0.041 (0.027) $p = 0.125$	-0.075 (0.049) $p = 0.128$	-0.031 (0.064) $p = 0.623$
Newsletter opening (SD)	0.014 (0.015) $p = 0.340$	0.026 (0.027) $p = 0.342$	0.045 (0.020) $p = 0.026$	0.017 (0.023) $p = 0.462$	0.031 (0.043) $p = 0.463$	0.181 (0.084) $p = 0.031$
N	1,052	1,052	579	1,052	1,052	579
LLS aggregation *N*	—	—	573	—	—	573

Notes: As in Table D.1.

Table D.4: Complete Estimates: Conservative Voters (Attitude 7–10)

	AfD			CDU		
Outcome	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS
Vote intention (pp)	1.66	3.49	4.81	-0.87	-1.83	-2.16
	(0.72)	(1.52)	(1.69)	(0.63)	(1.32)	(1.55)
	$p = 0.022$	$p = 0.022$	$p = 0.004$	$p = 0.168$	$p = 0.167$	$p = 0.164$
Thermometer (SD)	0.040	0.085	0.094	-0.016	-0.034	-0.074
	(0.015)	(0.031)	(0.037)	(0.014)	(0.030)	(0.034)
	$p = 0.007$	$p = 0.007$	$p = 0.011$	$p = 0.264$	$p = 0.259$	$p = 0.029$
Support index (SD)	0.026	0.056	0.104	-0.019	-0.040	-0.091
	(0.015)	(0.031)	(0.036)	(0.015)	(0.032)	(0.037)
	$p = 0.072$	$p = 0.072$	$p = 0.004$	$p = 0.210$	$p = 0.206$	$p = 0.014$
Campaign help (SD)	0.005	0.010	0.075	-0.007	-0.015	-0.104
	(0.016)	(0.033)	(0.037)	(0.016)	(0.034)	(0.038)
	$p = 0.767$	$p = 0.767$	$p = 0.044$	$p = 0.655$	$p = 0.653$	$p = 0.007$
Donation willingness (SD)	0.008	0.016	0.040	-0.017	-0.035	-0.048
	(0.015)	(0.032)	(0.039)	(0.015)	(0.032)	(0.039)
	$p = 0.612$	$p = 0.611$	$p = 0.313$	$p = 0.283$	$p = 0.282$	$p = 0.223$
Newsletter opening (SD)	-0.002	-0.004	0.086	0.003	0.006	-0.008
	(0.018)	(0.038)	(0.038)	(0.017)	(0.036)	(0.042)
	$p = 0.920$	$p = 0.920$	$p = 0.025$	$p = 0.874$	$p = 0.874$	$p = 0.846$
N	3,165	3,165	1,622	3,165	3,165	1,622
LLS aggregation *N*	—	—	1,560	—	—	1,560

Notes: As in Table D.1.

Table D.5: Effects on Vote Intention for Each Party

	Pooled		Liberal (0–4)		Moderate (5–6)		Conservative (7–10)	
Vote intention for	RF	2SLS	RF	2SLS	RF	2SLS	RF	2SLS
AfD	1.06**	2.14**	-0.84	-1.67	-0.06	-0.10	1.66**	3.49**
	(0.54)	(1.08)	(0.87)	(1.78)	(0.89)	(1.63)	(0.72)	(1.52)
CDU	-0.64	-1.28	1.10	2.19	-0.75	-1.37	-0.87	-1.83
	(0.50)	(1.01)	(1.09)	(2.16)	(1.14)	(2.07)	(0.63)	(1.32)
AfD + CDU	0.43	0.86	0.26	0.52	-0.80	-1.47	0.79	1.66
	(0.61)	(1.23)	(1.24)	(2.46)	(1.30)	(2.38)	(0.75)	(1.58)
BSW	0.13	0.26	0.46	0.92	1.31	2.39	-0.27	-0.57
	(0.39)	(0.78)	(0.80)	(1.60)	(0.83)	(1.50)	(0.51)	(1.09)
Greens	-0.45	-0.90	-1.14	-2.27	-1.58	-2.88	0.10	0.22
	(0.35)	(0.71)	(1.26)	(2.51)	(0.96)	(1.76)	(0.26)	(0.55)
Left	-0.02	-0.05	-0.20	-0.40	0.81	1.48	-0.29	-0.61
	(0.30)	(0.60)	(1.07)	(2.13)	(0.77)	(1.42)	(0.26)	(0.55)
SPD	0.04	0.08	0.47	0.93	0.69	1.27	-0.34	-0.71
	(0.39)	(0.78)	(1.13)	(2.26)	(1.02)	(1.87)	(0.42)	(0.89)
FDP	-0.11	-0.22	0.34	0.68	-0.30	-0.55	-0.10	-0.21
	(0.22)	(0.45)	(0.58)	(1.16)	(0.55)	(1.00)	(0.26)	(0.56)
Other party	-0.01	-0.03	-0.19	-0.39	-0.13	-0.24	0.10	0.22
	(0.34)	(0.68)	(0.78)	(1.54)	(0.89)	(1.63)	(0.40)	(0.85)

Notes: Effects on the vote-intention indicator for each party, in percentage points; robust standard errors in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$. Vote intention is a single choice, so the indicators are mutually exclusive and the AfD + CDU row is the net flow into the two parties. RF effects are per one-point more liberal signal; 2SLS effects are per one-point more liberal perceived CDU position. Controls of equation (1); samples as in Figure 4.

Table D.6: Effects on Turnout Likelihood

Population	RF	2SLS	LLS	*N* (RF/2SLS)	LLS aggregation *N*
Pooled	0.001 (0.012)	0.003 (0.024)	-0.025 (0.027)	5,040	2,570
Liberal (0–4)	0.023 (0.031)	0.047 (0.063)	0.027 (0.065)	823	436
Moderate (5–6)	-0.004 (0.029)	-0.007 (0.052)	0.160** (0.066)	1,052	573
Conservative (7–10)	-0.005 (0.014)	-0.011 (0.030)	-0.005 (0.031)	3,165	1,560

Notes: Standardized stated likelihood of voting; coefficients in standard deviations, robust standard errors (Bayesian bootstrap for LLS) in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$. Estimators, samples, and controls as in Tables D.1 to D.4.

Table D.7: Differences Between Attitude Groups

Outcome	Contrast	RF	2SLS	LLS
AfD vote intention (pp)	Liberal (0–4) minus Conservative (7–10)	-2.50**	-5.16**	-4.26*
		(1.13)	(2.34)	(2.28)
	Moderate (5–6) minus Conservative (7–10)	-1.71	-3.60	-2.43
		(1.15)	(2.23)	(2.41)
	Liberal (0–4) minus Moderate (5–6)	-0.78	-1.57	-1.84
		(1.24)	(2.42)	(2.26)
CDU vote intention (pp)	Liberal (0–4) minus Conservative (7–10)	1.97	4.02	2.68
		(1.26)	(2.53)	(2.47)
	Moderate (5–6) minus Conservative (7–10)	0.12	0.47	3.52
		(1.30)	(2.46)	(2.94)
	Liberal (0–4) minus Moderate (5–6)	1.85	3.56	-0.84
		(1.57)	(2.99)	(3.07)
AfD thermometer (SD)	Liberal (0–4) minus Conservative (7–10)	-0.025	-0.054	-0.060
		(0.026)	(0.052)	(0.053)
	Moderate (5–6) minus Conservative (7–10)	-0.064**	-0.128***	-0.046
		(0.025)	(0.050)	(0.057)
	Liberal (0–4) minus Moderate (5–6)	0.039	0.075	-0.014
		(0.030)	(0.057)	(0.058)
CDU thermometer (SD)	Liberal (0–4) minus Conservative (7–10)	0.075**	0.150**	0.107*
		(0.029)	(0.060)	(0.064)
	Moderate (5–6) minus Conservative (7–10)	0.010	0.022	0.081
		(0.028)	(0.054)	(0.061)
	Liberal (0–4) minus Moderate (5–6)	0.065*	0.128*	0.026
		(0.035)	(0.068)	(0.074)
AfD support index (SD)	Liberal (0–4) minus Conservative (7–10)	-0.033	-0.069	-0.101*
		(0.024)	(0.049)	(0.054)
	Moderate (5–6) minus Conservative (7–10)	-0.050**	-0.099**	-0.081
		(0.024)	(0.047)	(0.051)
	Liberal (0–4) minus Moderate (5–6)	0.017	0.030	-0.020
		(0.027)	(0.052)	(0.054)
CDU support index (SD)	Liberal (0–4) minus Conservative (7–10)	0.055*	0.112*	0.113*
		(0.029)	(0.059)	(0.061)
	Moderate (5–6) minus Conservative (7–10)	-0.005	-0.003	0.161**
		(0.029)	(0.055)	(0.071)
	Liberal (0–4) minus Moderate (5–6)	0.060*	0.115*	-0.048
		(0.035)	(0.067)	(0.076)

Notes: Differences between the group-specific coefficients of Tables D.2 to D.4; standard errors in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$. RF and 2SLS differences use the HC1 variances of the separate regressions, which are independent across groups. LLS differences use the paired bootstrap draws, so their standard errors account for the common draws.

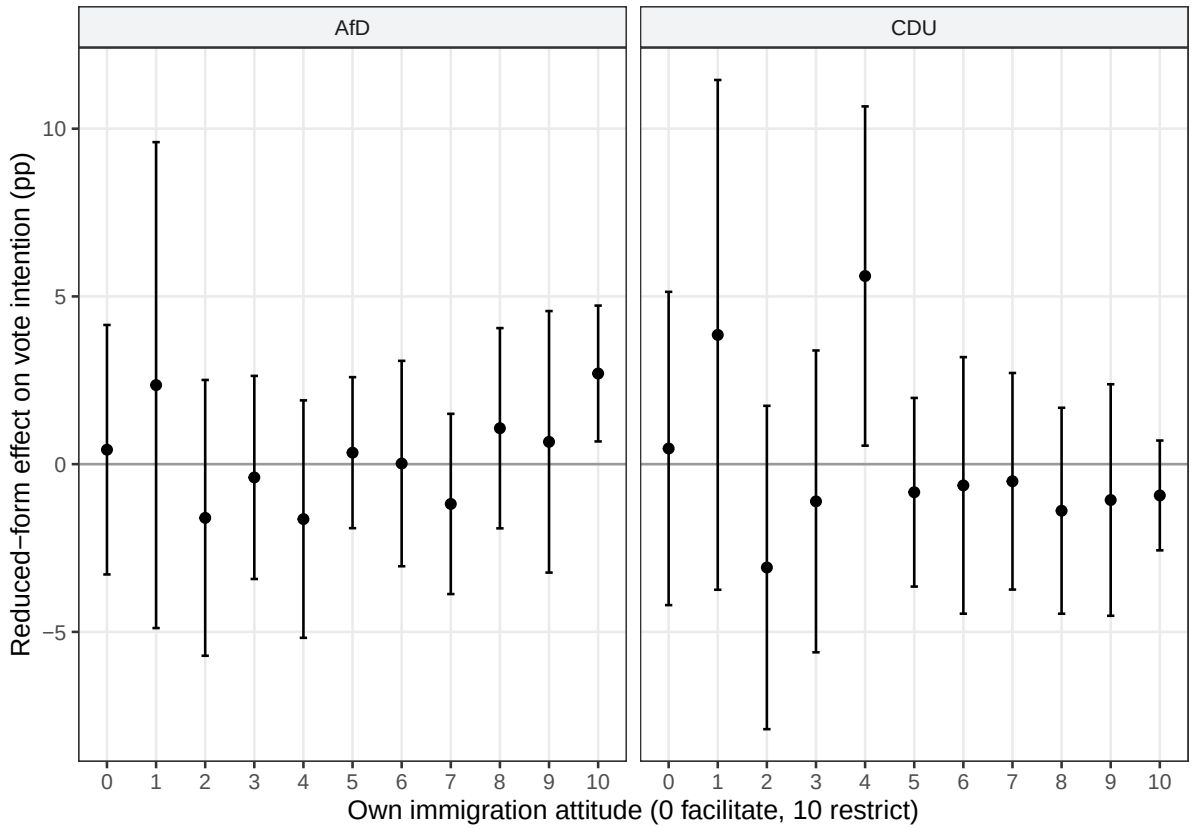


Figure D.1: Reduced-Form Vote Effects at Each Attitude Value
Note: Separate signal coefficients for each of the eleven pre-treatment attitude values, from a regression with attitude fixed effects, attitude-by-signal interactions, and the baseline controls, robust standard errors, 95 percent confidence intervals.

Table D.8: Interaction of the Signal with the Continuous Attitude

Outcome or specification	Coefficient	SE	*p*
Panel A. Signal × attitude, by outcome			
AfD vote intention (pp)	0.343	0.163	.036
CDU vote intention (pp)	-0.167	0.168	.319
AfD thermometer (SD)	0.008	0.004	.031
CDU thermometer (SD)	-0.005	0.004	.268
AfD support index (SD)	0.006	0.003	.083
CDU support index (SD)	-0.004	0.004	.335
Panel B. AfD vote intention (pp) and region			
With signal × East added: signal × attitude	0.314	0.167	.060
With signal × East added: signal × East	1.106	0.996	.267
East Germany only: signal × attitude	0.521	0.228	.022
West Germany only: signal × attitude	0.072	0.241	.764
N (Panel A)	5,040		

Notes: Coefficient of the signal interacted with the continuous pre-treatment attitude (0–10), in a regression with attitude fixed effects, the signal, and the baseline controls, robust standard errors. A positive coefficient means that a more liberal signal has a more positive effect among more conservative respondents. Votes in percentage points per attitude point; other outcomes in standard deviations. Panel B adds, for AfD vote intention, a signal-by-East interaction to the same specification and reports both interaction coefficients, and estimates the specification within East Germany (3,037 respondents) and West Germany (2,003) without the East indicator.

Table D.9: Alternative Definitions of the Conservative Group

	Attitude ≥ 6			Attitude ≥ 7 (main)			Attitude ≥ 8		
Outcome	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS
AfD vote intention (pp)	1.61**	3.34**	4.52***	1.66**	3.49**	4.81***	2.11***	4.57***	5.88***
	(0.68)	(1.40)	(1.59)	(0.72)	(1.52)	(1.69)	(0.80)	(1.74)	(2.00)
CDU vote intention (pp)	-0.85	-1.77	-1.68	-0.87	-1.83	-2.16	-0.89	-1.92	-1.96
	(0.60)	(1.24)	(1.43)	(0.63)	(1.32)	(1.55)	(0.68)	(1.45)	(1.78)
AfD thermometer (sd)	0.040***	0.082***	0.090***	0.040***	0.085***	0.094**	0.052***	0.111***	0.126***
	(0.014)	(0.029)	(0.035)	(0.015)	(0.031)	(0.037)	(0.016)	(0.035)	(0.042)
CDU thermometer (sd)	-0.009	-0.019	-0.056*	-0.016	-0.034	-0.074**	-0.014	-0.030	-0.051
	(0.014)	(0.028)	(0.032)	(0.014)	(0.030)	(0.034)	(0.016)	(0.034)	(0.037)
AfD support index (sd)	0.025*	0.052*	0.094***	0.026*	0.056*	0.104***	0.035**	0.076**	0.147***
	(0.014)	(0.029)	(0.034)	(0.015)	(0.031)	(0.036)	(0.016)	(0.035)	(0.041)
CDU support index (sd)	-0.018	-0.036	-0.071**	-0.019	-0.040	-0.091**	-0.021	-0.046	-0.083**
	(0.014)	(0.029)	(0.034)	(0.015)	(0.032)	(0.037)	(0.017)	(0.035)	(0.041)
N (RF/2SLS) / LLS aggregation	3,529		1,762	3,165		1,560	2,604		1,232

Notes: Estimates for respondents with attitude at or above 6, 7 (the main definition), and 8. Each cell reports the coefficient and its standard error (robust for RF and 2SLS, Bayesian bootstrap for LLS); *, **, *** denote $p < .10$, .05, .01. Vote effects in percentage points; other outcomes in standard deviations. Estimators and controls as in Table D.4.

E LLS Implementation, Bandwidth, and Placebo Tests

The LLS estimator fits, at each evaluation point of the normalized learning-rate distribution, a kernel-weighted regression of the outcome on the posterior belief and the controls, and averages the local posterior coefficients with the mass of respondents at each point. Our implementation uses the companion R package of Balla-Elliott (2026): an Epanechnikov kernel, bandwidth $h = .075$ on within-population normalized ranks of the learning rate, automatic boundary trimming, and 1,000 Bayesian-bootstrap draws whose standard deviation, computed after omitting the twenty largest absolute draws, 2 percent, the package's default, gives the standard error. Table E.3 reports the untrimmed standard errors: they are 4 to 8 percent larger, and the only estimates in the table whose significance at the 5 percent level depends on the trimming are the conservative-group AfD campaign-help effect ($p = .044$ with trimming, .056 without) and the pooled CDU thermometer (.048 and .063), in the pooled LLS that the paper does not interpret. In the attitude groups, the only controls are indicators for the categorical CDU prior. In a few windows the posterior does not vary within any prior category, so the local coefficient would be identified only from differences across prior categories, the variation the controls are there to remove; we exclude these windows from the aggregation (8 of 100 windows in the attitude groups and 3 of 41 in the pooled sample, under 4 percent of the positive updaters in every population) while keeping their respondents in the neighboring local fits. The classification uses the regressors alone, is identical across outcomes, and did not change in any bootstrap draw. Keeping these windows, as the package does, gives 4.9 rather than 4.8 percentage points for the conservative-group AfD vote effect. Table E.2 reports two further variants: adding the demographic controls of equation (1) to the categorical prior within attitude groups, and requiring positive residual degrees of freedom in every retained window.

Bandwidth. We report every LLS estimate at $h = .05$, .075, .10, and .15 (Table E.1 and Figure E.1). The main bandwidth is .075, the narrowest on this grid at which the pre-treatment placebo tests pass among conservative voters (Table E.4): at .05 the posterior predicts the pre-treatment attitude in this group (0.050 standard deviations per posterior point, SE 0.023), in the direction that would inflate the AfD effect, and at .075 and above it does not (0.018 at .075 and .10, 0.003 at .15). Every conservative-group estimate is larger in magnitude at .05 than at the main bandwidth, on both parties and on stated and behavioral measures, although at that bandwidth the support rule excludes 29 of the 39 evaluation windows in this group, so these estimates aggregate over a reduced support (Table E.1). This is the bias-variance trade-off of the estimator: narrow windows limit contamination across learning rates, wide windows smooth toward the updating-weighted average that 2SLS recovers, and the main bandwidth is therefore a conservative choice relative to the narrowest feasible one. In terms of conventional significance, the AfD vote, the CDU thermometer, the CDU support index, and CDU campaign help among conservative voters are significant at every bandwidth from .05 to .15; the AfD thermometer, AfD support index, and AfD newsletter effects are significant from .05 to .10 and not at .15, where the point estimates remain positive at roughly half the main magnitude; the CDU donation effect is significant only at .05, and AfD campaign help only at the main bandwidth. In the pooled sample, the AfD vote effect is significant at every bandwidth, and the AfD thermometer and support-index effects at .05 and .075 but not at the wider bandwidths.

Table E.1: LLS Estimates at Bandwidths .05, .075, .10, and .15

		AfD				CDU			
Outcome	Population	h = .05	h = .075	h = .10	h = .15	h = .05	h = .075	h = .10	h = .15
Vote intention (pp)	Pooled	3.58*** (1.38)	3.32*** (1.26)	3.12** (1.26)	2.85*** (0.93)	-2.29* (1.27)	-1.61 (1.19)	-1.36 (1.10)	-1.36 (0.89)
	Liberal (0–4)	2.28 (1.76)	0.55 (1.49)	0.61 (1.46)	0.37 (1.50)	0.85 (1.80)	0.51 (1.86)	0.60 (1.94)	2.35 (1.98)
	Moderate (5–6)	0.47 (1.94)	2.39 (1.72)	2.94* (1.71)	2.34 (1.63)	0.70 (2.62)	1.35 (2.43)	1.66 (2.34)	1.62 (1.93)
	Conservative (7–10)	5.96*** (2.20)	4.81*** (1.69)	4.64*** (1.68)	4.17*** (1.51)	-4.17* (2.14)	-2.16 (1.55)	-2.03 (1.53)	-2.25* (1.18)
Thermometer (SD)	Pooled	0.066** (0.032)	0.062** (0.028)	0.047* (0.028)	0.034 (0.021)	-0.066** (0.030)	-0.055** (0.028)	-0.051* (0.026)	-0.055** (0.022)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.056 (0.045)	0.034 (0.036)	0.036 (0.036)	0.016 (0.039)	0.072 (0.059)	0.033 (0.054)	0.029 (0.054)	0.044 (0.050)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.007 (0.049)	0.048 (0.044)	0.050 (0.043)	0.021 (0.038)	-0.035 (0.055)	0.007 (0.050)	0.016 (0.049)	-0.018 (0.042)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.104** (0.046)	0.094** (0.037)	0.091** (0.037)	0.051 (0.034)	-0.137*** (0.046)	-0.074** (0.034)	-0.071** (0.033)	-0.060** (0.028)
Support index (SD)	Pooled	0.063** (0.031)	0.059** (0.027)	0.046* (0.028)	0.033 (0.020)	-0.074** (0.032)	-0.055* (0.029)	-0.052* (0.027)	-0.060*** (0.022)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.042 (0.051)	0.002 (0.039)	0.003 (0.039)	0.002 (0.040)	0.006 (0.048)	0.022 (0.046)	0.021 (0.048)	0.051 (0.048)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.023 (0.043)	0.023 (0.037)	0.034 (0.037)	0.024 (0.035)	0.007 (0.060)	0.070 (0.060)	0.080 (0.058)	0.028 (0.044)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.120*** (0.044)	0.104*** (0.036)	0.100*** (0.036)	0.057* (0.033)	-0.177*** (0.050)	-0.091** (0.037)	-0.085** (0.036)	-0.089*** (0.029)
Campaign help (SD)	Pooled	0.034 (0.032)	0.036 (0.028)	0.025 (0.029)	0.015 (0.021)	-0.065** (0.032)	-0.047* (0.029)	-0.045* (0.027)	-0.038* (0.021)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.054 (0.058)	0.007 (0.044)	0.003 (0.043)	0.018 (0.040)	-0.014 (0.051)	0.001 (0.042)	-0.001 (0.043)	0.013 (0.042)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.053 (0.038)	-0.020 (0.034)	-0.004 (0.034)	0.021 (0.032)	0.019 (0.057)	0.109** (0.051)	0.108** (0.048)	0.048 (0.040)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.076* (0.044)	0.075** (0.037)	0.073* (0.037)	0.032 (0.036)	-0.176*** (0.052)	-0.104*** (0.038)	-0.096** (0.038)	-0.091*** (0.030)
Donation willingness (SD)	Pooled	0.003 (0.032)	-0.004 (0.029)	-0.021 (0.030)	-0.018 (0.022)	-0.048 (0.033)	-0.037 (0.031)	-0.034 (0.030)	-0.065*** (0.024)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.004 (0.063)	-0.062 (0.051)	-0.063 (0.050)	-0.053 (0.051)	-0.098 (0.068)	0.012 (0.061)	0.015 (0.060)	0.051 (0.057)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.068 (0.059)	-0.035 (0.064)	-0.023 (0.061)	-0.032 (0.043)	-0.008 (0.066)	-0.031 (0.064)	-0.019 (0.061)	-0.029 (0.049)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.061 (0.049)	0.040 (0.039)	0.038 (0.039)	-0.009 (0.034)	-0.129*** (0.048)	-0.048 (0.039)	-0.043 (0.039)	-0.059* (0.034)
Newsletter opening (SD)	Pooled	0.058** (0.023)	0.059** (0.024)	0.062** (0.025)	0.023 (0.020)	0.009 (0.031)	0.014 (0.028)	0.005 (0.025)	-0.010 (0.022)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.059** (0.029)	0.003 (0.030)	0.011 (0.032)	0.008 (0.026)	-0.002 (0.025)	0.018 (0.027)	0.015 (0.027)	-0.003 (0.027)
	Moderate (5–6)	0.054*** (0.020)	0.045** (0.020)	0.039 (0.025)	0.028 (0.028)	0.059 (0.046)	0.181** (0.084)	0.199** (0.084)	0.074 (0.049)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.090** (0.040)	0.086** (0.038)	0.087** (0.039)	0.046 (0.036)	-0.041 (0.059)	-0.008 (0.042)	-0.006 (0.041)	-0.031 (0.032)

Notes: Coefficients per one-point more liberal perceived CDU position; Bayesian-bootstrap standard errors in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$. Votes in percentage points; other outcomes in standard deviations. Aggregation samples at h = .05, .075, .10, and .15: 2,570, 2,570, 2,626, and 2,571 pooled; 346, 436, 436, and 447 liberal; 455, 573, 573, and 576 moderate; 1,267, 1,560, 1,560, and 1,603 conservative. At h = .05 the support rule excludes 3 of 41 evaluation windows in the pooled sample but 28 of 35, 21 of 29, and 29 of 39 in the liberal, moderate, and conservative groups, so the attitude-group estimates at that bandwidth aggregate over a reduced support.

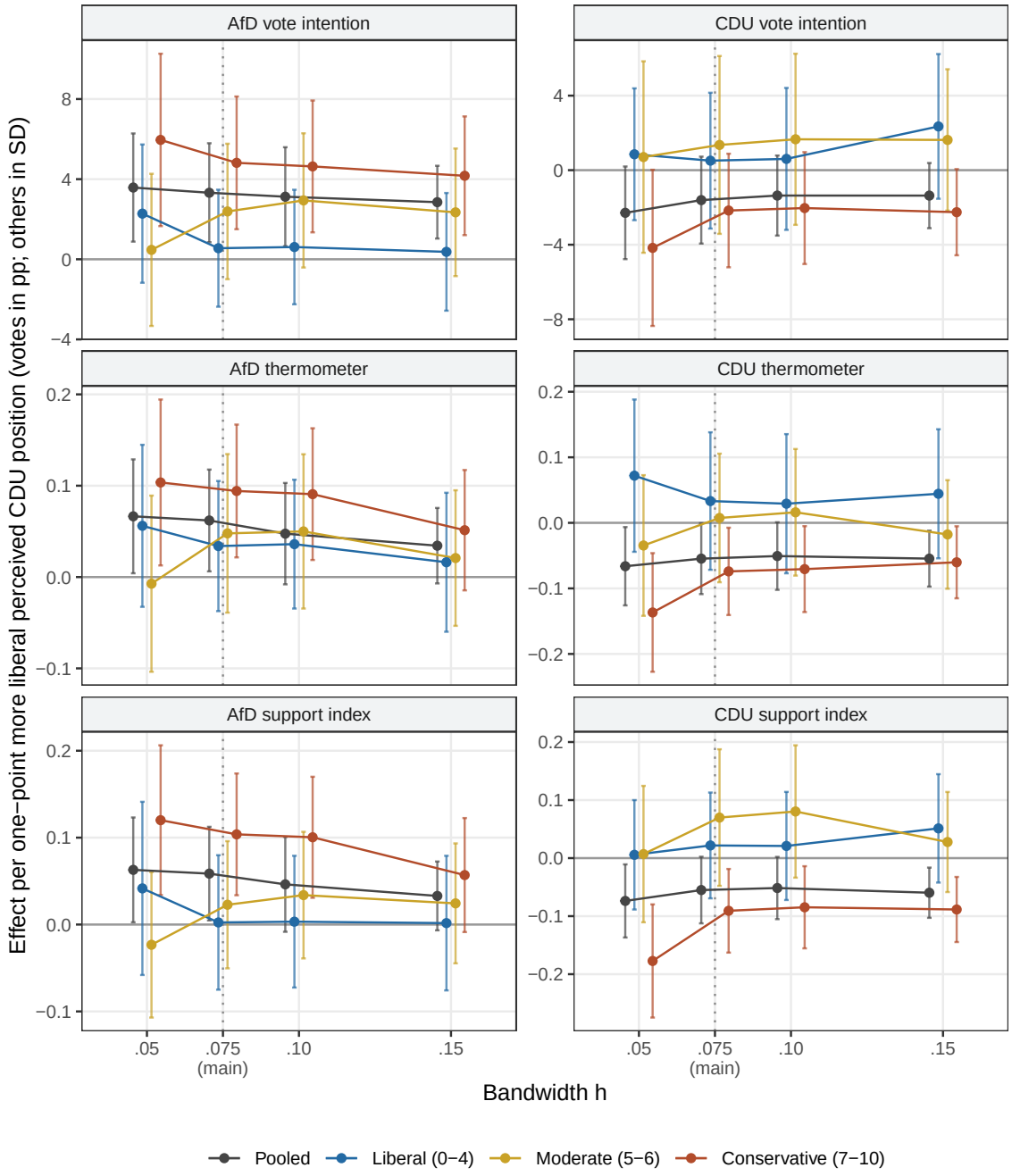


Figure E.1: LLS Sensitivity to Bandwidth

Note: Point estimates and 95 percent confidence intervals at h = .05, .075 (the main bandwidth, dotted line), .10, and .15, per one-point more liberal perceived CDU position; lines connect the estimates of each population. Votes in percentage points; thermometer and support index in standard deviations.

Table E.2: Alternative LLS Specifications

		AfD			CDU		
Outcome	Population	Main	+ demographics	Positive d.f.	Main	+ demographics	Positive d.f.
Vote intention (pp)	Pooled	3.32***	–	3.32***	-1.61	–	-1.61
		(1.26)		(1.26)	(1.19)		(1.19)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.55	0.24	0.56	0.51	-0.42	0.51
		(1.49)	(1.58)	(1.50)	(1.86)	(1.95)	(1.87)
	Moderate (5–6)	2.39	2.18	2.39	1.35	0.56	1.35
		(1.72)	(1.90)	(1.72)	(2.43)	(2.77)	(2.43)
	Conservative (7–10)	4.81***	4.57***	4.81***	-2.16	-1.91	-2.16
		(1.69)	(1.66)	(1.69)	(1.55)	(1.60)	(1.55)
Thermometer (SD)	Pooled	0.062**	–	0.062**	-0.055**	–	-0.055**
		(0.028)		(0.028)	(0.028)		(0.028)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.034	0.018	0.027	0.033	-0.060	0.040
		(0.036)	(0.046)	(0.036)	(0.054)	(0.056)	(0.053)
	Moderate (5–6)	0.048	0.068	0.048	0.007	0.043	0.007
		(0.044)	(0.046)	(0.044)	(0.050)	(0.062)	(0.050)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.094**	0.093***	0.094**	-0.074**	-0.071**	-0.074**
		(0.037)	(0.035)	(0.037)	(0.034)	(0.034)	(0.034)
Support index (SD)	Pooled	0.059**	–	0.059**	-0.055*	–	-0.055*
		(0.027)		(0.027)	(0.029)		(0.029)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.002	-0.011	0.004	0.022	-0.057	0.024
		(0.039)	(0.043)	(0.040)	(0.046)	(0.050)	(0.047)
	Moderate (5–6)	0.023	0.027	0.023	0.070	0.097	0.070
		(0.037)	(0.045)	(0.037)	(0.060)	(0.071)	(0.060)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.104***	0.099***	0.104***	-0.091**	-0.081**	-0.091**
		(0.036)	(0.034)	(0.036)	(0.037)	(0.037)	(0.037)

Notes: Main: the specification of the paper. + demographics: adds the demographic controls of equation (1) to the categorical CDU prior within each attitude group, at the main bandwidth; the pooled specification already includes them, so that cell is marked with a dash. Its aggregation samples are 432, 564, and 1,560 respondents in the liberal, moderate, and conservative groups. Positive d.f.: additionally excludes from the aggregation retained windows with no residual degrees of freedom, which affects two liberal windows and no other population. Both variants use the same 1,000 draws. Bayesian-bootstrap standard errors in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$.

Table E.3: LLS Inference With and Without Trimming of the Bootstrap Draws

		Trimmed bootstrap SD		Untrimmed bootstrap SD	
Outcome	Coefficient	SE	p	SE	p
Pooled					
AfD vote intention (pp)	3.32	1.26	.008	1.33	.013
CDU vote intention (pp)	-1.61	1.19	.177	1.26	.204
AfD thermometer (sd)	0.062	0.028	.029	0.030	.039
CDU thermometer (sd)	-0.055	0.028	.048	0.029	.063
AfD support index (sd)	0.059	0.027	.033	0.029	.044
CDU support index (sd)	-0.055	0.029	.060	0.031	.074
AfD campaign help (sd)	0.036	0.028	.208	0.030	.231
CDU campaign help (sd)	-0.047	0.029	.097	0.030	.116
AfD donation willingness (sd)	-0.004	0.029	.893	0.031	.900
CDU donation willingness (sd)	-0.037	0.031	.231	0.032	.252
AfD newsletter opening (sd)	0.059	0.024	.014	0.026	.022
CDU newsletter opening (sd)	0.014	0.028	.623	0.030	.645
Conservative (7–10)					
AfD vote intention (pp)	4.81	1.69	.004	1.80	.007
CDU vote intention (pp)	-2.16	1.55	.164	1.65	.189
AfD thermometer (sd)	0.094	0.037	.011	0.039	.016
CDU thermometer (sd)	-0.074	0.034	.029	0.036	.040
AfD support index (sd)	0.104	0.036	.004	0.038	.006
CDU support index (sd)	-0.091	0.037	.014	0.039	.020
AfD campaign help (sd)	0.075	0.037	.044	0.039	.056
CDU campaign help (sd)	-0.104	0.038	.007	0.040	.010
AfD donation willingness (sd)	0.040	0.039	.313	0.041	.337
CDU donation willingness (sd)	-0.048	0.039	.223	0.041	.248
AfD newsletter opening (sd)	0.086	0.038	.025	0.041	.035
CDU newsletter opening (sd)	-0.008	0.042	.846	0.045	.857

Notes: Main-specification LLS coefficients with the standard error and normal p-value used in the paper, which omit the twenty largest absolute draws of the 1,000 Bayesian-bootstrap draws when computing the standard deviation, the package's default, and with the untrimmed standard deviation. Votes in percentage points; other outcomes in standard deviations.

Table E.4: Pre-Treatment Placebo Tests

	RF	LLS			
Placebo outcome, bandwidth	Pooled	Pooled	Liberal (0–4)	Moderate (5–6)	Conservative (7–10)
Pre-treatment immigration attitude (SD)					
$h = .05$	0.009	-0.052	-0.031	-0.012	0.050**
	(0.012)	(0.038)	(0.039)	(0.012)	(0.023)
$h = .075$ (main)		-0.036	-0.021	0.004	0.018
		(0.033)	(0.033)	(0.010)	(0.017)
$h = .10$		-0.038	-0.020	0.005	0.018
		(0.033)	(0.033)	(0.010)	(0.017)
$h = .15$		-0.029	0.004	-0.007	0.003
		(0.024)	(0.030)	(0.008)	(0.015)
Pre-treatment AfD prior, liberal-coded (SD)					
$h = .05$	-0.007	0.071**	0.033	0.063	-0.046
	(0.012)	(0.030)	(0.033)	(0.088)	(0.044)
$h = .075$ (main)		0.069**	0.140**	0.018	0.024
		(0.030)	(0.056)	(0.067)	(0.038)
$h = .10$		0.070**	0.160***	0.008	0.015
		(0.030)	(0.060)	(0.061)	(0.036)
$h = .15$		0.023	0.156**	-0.004	0.014
		(0.022)	(0.072)	(0.050)	(0.031)

Notes: Effects on two standardized pre-treatment variables that the information cannot affect: the respondent's own immigration attitude and the liberal-coded prior belief about the AfD's position. The RF column uses the full sample; LLS uses positive updaters and the main controls, at each of the four bandwidths of Table E.1. Robust standard errors (Bayesian bootstrap for LLS) in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$.

Table E.5: Reduced Form and 2SLS on the LLS Samples

		Positive updaters		LLS aggregation sample		Aggregation sample, LLS controls	
Outcome	Population	RF	2SLS	RF	2SLS	RF	2SLS
AfD vote intention (pp)	Pooled	1.74**	2.31**	1.71**	2.01**	1.71**	2.01**
		(0.77)	(1.01)	(0.78)	(0.91)	(0.78)	(0.91)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.14	0.20	0.33	0.40	-0.01	-0.01
		(1.23)	(1.70)	(1.25)	(1.50)	(1.24)	(1.46)
	Moderate (5–6)	1.80	2.13	1.93	2.15	1.58	1.75
		(1.28)	(1.52)	(1.25)	(1.39)	(1.28)	(1.41)
	Conservative (7–10)	2.13**	2.94**	2.08*	2.52*	2.29**	2.78**
		(1.05)	(1.44)	(1.08)	(1.30)	(1.09)	(1.32)
CDU vote intention (pp)	Pooled	-0.61	-0.81	-0.73	-0.86	-0.73	-0.86
		(0.72)	(0.95)	(0.73)	(0.86)	(0.73)	(0.86)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.12	-0.17	-0.09	-0.11	0.38	0.45
		(1.51)	(2.09)	(1.54)	(1.87)	(1.56)	(1.84)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.68	-0.81	-0.77	-0.86	-0.82	-0.91
		(1.56)	(1.84)	(1.59)	(1.77)	(1.60)	(1.76)
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.46	-0.64	-0.63	-0.76	-0.70	-0.84
		(0.93)	(1.28)	(0.94)	(1.14)	(0.95)	(1.15)
AfD campaign help (sd)	Pooled	0.000	0.000	-0.004	-0.004	-0.004	-0.004
		(0.016)	(0.021)	(0.016)	(0.019)	(0.016)	(0.019)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.008	-0.011	-0.006	-0.007	-0.012	-0.014
		(0.030)	(0.041)	(0.030)	(0.036)	(0.029)	(0.035)
	Moderate (5–6)	0.029	0.034	0.031	0.035	0.022	0.024
		(0.025)	(0.029)	(0.024)	(0.027)	(0.025)	(0.028)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.000	0.000	-0.005	-0.007	-0.003	-0.004
		(0.022)	(0.031)	(0.023)	(0.028)	(0.023)	(0.028)
CDU campaign help (sd)	Pooled	-0.025	-0.033	-0.026	-0.030	-0.026	-0.030
		(0.017)	(0.023)	(0.017)	(0.021)	(0.017)	(0.021)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.005	0.007	-0.001	-0.002	0.009	0.011
		(0.031)	(0.042)	(0.031)	(0.038)	(0.031)	(0.037)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.014	-0.017	-0.013	-0.014	-0.018	-0.019
		(0.034)	(0.040)	(0.034)	(0.038)	(0.034)	(0.037)
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.030	-0.041	-0.029	-0.036	-0.031	-0.038
		(0.023)	(0.032)	(0.024)	(0.029)	(0.024)	(0.029)

Notes: Vote effects in percentage points and campaign help in standard deviations, estimated on the LLS input sample of positive updaters, on the LLS aggregation sample, and on the aggregation sample with the LLS control set. Robust standard errors (Bayesian bootstrap for LLS) in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$.

F Specification Checks for the Reduced Form and 2SLS

Table F.1: Sample Restrictions and Speeders

		Including speeders			Passed second attention check			Rated information credible			Posterior not farther from signal		
Outcome	Population	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS
AfD vote (pp)	Pooled	1.10**	2.28**	3.64***	1.16**	2.18**	2.92**	1.29**	2.51**	3.23**	1.69***	2.68***	3.60***
		(0.53)	(1.09)	(1.27)	(0.56)	(1.04)	(1.29)	(0.61)	(1.18)	(1.31)	(0.58)	(0.92)	(1.38)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.75	-1.50	0.21	-0.19	-0.33	0.48	-0.67	-1.30	-0.74	-0.15	-0.22	2.28
		(0.85)	(1.76)	(1.42)	(0.85)	(1.51)	(1.43)	(0.93)	(1.84)	(1.63)	(0.88)	(1.28)	(1.76)
	Moderate (5–6)	0.07	0.13	3.39*	-0.08	-0.13	1.18	-0.08	-0.14	4.63**	0.73	1.12	0.91
		(0.89)	(1.69)	(1.91)	(0.93)	(1.51)	(1.64)	(0.98)	(1.74)	(1.96)	(0.94)	(1.42)	(2.02)
	Conservative (7–10)	1.66**	3.60**	4.86***	1.75**	3.54**	3.94**	2.17**	4.44**	4.22**	1.99**	3.31**	5.28***
		(0.71)	(1.55)	(1.69)	(0.74)	(1.51)	(1.74)	(0.85)	(1.73)	(1.77)	(0.79)	(1.32)	(1.84)
CDU vote (pp)	Pooled	-0.62	-1.27	-1.73	-0.58	-1.09	-1.80	-0.95	-1.86	-1.52	-0.87	-1.37	-2.09
		(0.50)	(1.03)	(1.17)	(0.53)	(0.98)	(1.23)	(0.61)	(1.18)	(1.43)	(0.55)	(0.88)	(1.29)
	Liberal (0–4)	1.27	2.56	1.03	1.00	1.76	-0.20	1.71	3.29	2.87	0.57	0.82	0.85
		(1.08)	(2.16)	(1.90)	(1.12)	(1.98)	(1.70)	(1.24)	(2.37)	(2.00)	(1.11)	(1.61)	(1.80)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.98	-1.86	0.75	-0.86	-1.39	-0.12	-0.07	-0.13	0.48	-0.71	-1.08	0.53
		(1.13)	(2.13)	(2.41)	(1.21)	(1.97)	(2.78)	(1.31)	(2.31)	(2.69)	(1.26)	(1.91)	(2.73)
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.80	-1.73	-2.12	-0.71	-1.44	-1.68	-1.87**	-3.82**	-2.61	-0.97	-1.61	-2.62
		(0.62)	(1.35)	(1.54)	(0.65)	(1.31)	(1.63)	(0.78)	(1.59)	(1.93)	(0.70)	(1.16)	(1.70)
N, pooled (RF/2SLS)		5,127			4,640			3,655			4,178		

Notes: Vote effects in percentage points. Including speeders adds the 87 respondents excluded by the survey firm's timing rule. The remaining three columns are the pre-registered restrictions: respondents who passed the second attention check, respondents who rated the information as at least somewhat trustworthy, and respondents whose posterior belief is no farther from the signal than their prior. Robust standard errors (Bayesian bootstrap for LLS) in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$.

Table F.2: Sample Restrictions and Speeders: All Outcomes, Reduced Form

Outcome	Including speeders	Passed second attention check	Rated information credible	Posterior not farther from signal
Pooled				
AfD vote intention (pp)	1.10** (0.53)	1.16** (0.56)	1.29** (0.61)	1.69*** (0.58)
CDU vote intention (pp)	-0.62 (0.50)	-0.58 (0.53)	-0.95 (0.61)	-0.87 (0.55)
AfD thermometer (sd)	0.022* (0.012)	0.026** (0.012)	0.029** (0.014)	0.035*** (0.013)
CDU thermometer (sd)	-0.006 (0.012)	0.000 (0.013)	0.004 (0.014)	-0.016 (0.013)
AfD support index (sd)	0.011 (0.011)	0.015 (0.012)	0.018 (0.013)	0.028** (0.012)
CDU support index (sd)	-0.015 (0.012)	-0.012 (0.013)	-0.016 (0.014)	-0.022* (0.014)
AfD campaign help (sd)	-0.007 (0.011)	-0.002 (0.012)	-0.003 (0.013)	0.004 (0.013)
CDU campaign help (sd)	-0.010 (0.012)	-0.006 (0.013)	-0.014 (0.015)	-0.016 (0.014)
AfD donation willingness (sd)	-0.005 (0.012)	-0.003 (0.013)	0.005 (0.014)	0.010 (0.013)
CDU donation willingness (sd)	-0.020* (0.012)	-0.020 (0.013)	-0.022 (0.014)	-0.021 (0.014)
AfD newsletter opening (sd)	0.002 (0.012)	0.003 (0.013)	0.003 (0.013)	0.016 (0.013)
CDU newsletter opening (sd)	0.002 (0.012)	-0.003 (0.013)	0.004 (0.015)	0.006 (0.014)
Conservative (7–10)				
AfD vote intention (pp)	1.66** (0.71)	1.75** (0.74)	2.17** (0.85)	1.99** (0.79)
CDU vote intention (pp)	-0.80 (0.62)	-0.71 (0.65)	-1.87** (0.78)	-0.97 (0.70)
AfD thermometer (sd)	0.038*** (0.015)	0.039*** (0.015)	0.049*** (0.018)	0.047*** (0.016)
CDU thermometer (sd)	-0.015 (0.014)	-0.011 (0.015)	-0.012 (0.017)	-0.027* (0.016)
AfD support index (sd)	0.024* (0.015)	0.027* (0.015)	0.039** (0.017)	0.037** (0.016)
CDU support index (sd)	-0.017 (0.015)	-0.017 (0.016)	-0.029 (0.019)	-0.026 (0.017)
AfD campaign help (sd)	0.002 (0.015)	0.007 (0.016)	0.012 (0.018)	0.004 (0.017)
CDU campaign help (sd)	-0.005 (0.016)	-0.007 (0.017)	-0.014 (0.020)	-0.016 (0.018)
AfD donation willingness (sd)	0.005 (0.015)	0.005 (0.016)	0.026 (0.018)	0.025 (0.017)
CDU donation willingness (sd)	-0.017 (0.015)	-0.019 (0.016)	-0.024 (0.018)	-0.018 (0.017)
AfD newsletter opening (sd)	-0.002 (0.018)	0.001 (0.019)	-0.003 (0.022)	0.015 (0.019)
CDU newsletter opening (sd)	0.003 (0.017)	-0.004 (0.018)	0.009 (0.022)	0.010 (0.019)

Notes: Reduced-form effects per one-point more liberal signal in the full sample and among conservative voters, under the four samples of Table F.1. Votes in percentage points; other outcomes in standard deviations. Robust standard errors in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$.

Table F.3: Anderson–Rubin Confidence Sets for the 2SLS Effects

Outcome	Population	First-stage F	AR p	95% AR confidence set
AfD vote intention (pp)	Pooled	375.3	.047	[0.03, 4.27]
	Liberal (0–4)	54.2	.332	[-5.62, 1.65]
	Moderate (5–6)	115.1	.951	[-3.43, 3.09]
	Conservative (7–10)	210.3	.021	[0.52, 6.54]
CDU vote intention (pp)	Pooled	375.3	.206	[-3.28, 0.71]
	Liberal (0–4)	54.2	.313	[-2.16, 6.61]
	Moderate (5–6)	115.1	.510	[-5.50, 2.76]
	Conservative (7–10)	210.3	.168	[-4.46, 0.78]
AfD thermometer (SD)	Pooled	375.3	.037	[0.003, 0.096]
	Liberal (0–4)	54.2	.464	[-0.055, 0.115]
	Moderate (5–6)	115.1	.249	[-0.124, 0.030]
	Conservative (7–10)	210.3	.006	[0.024, 0.148]
CDU thermometer (SD)	Pooled	375.3	.636	[-0.058, 0.036]
	Liberal (0–4)	54.2	.023	[0.017, 0.228]
	Moderate (5–6)	115.1	.791	[-0.101, 0.075]
	Conservative (7–10)	210.3	.264	[-0.093, 0.026]
AfD support index (SD)	Pooled	375.3	.257	[-0.019, 0.071]
	Liberal (0–4)	54.2	.731	[-0.094, 0.059]
	Moderate (5–6)	115.1	.215	[-0.116, 0.024]
	Conservative (7–10)	210.3	.072	[-0.005, 0.117]
CDU support index (SD)	Pooled	375.3	.228	[-0.077, 0.019]
	Liberal (0–4)	54.2	.148	[-0.026, 0.175]
	Moderate (5–6)	115.1	.335	[-0.134, 0.045]
	Conservative (7–10)	210.3	.210	[-0.102, 0.023]

Notes: Anderson–Rubin tests and 95 percent confidence sets for the 2SLS effect of the perceived CDU position. Votes in percentage points; other outcomes in standard deviations.

Table F.4: The Pre-Registered Gap Specification

Outcome	Population	2SLS (gap instrumented by signal)	First-stage F	95% AR set	LLS (positive gap-updaters)
AfD Vote intention (pp)	Pooled	4.11** (1.99)	96.6	[0.05, 8.03]	9.10*** (0.75)
	Liberal (0–4)	-21.67 (32.53)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	1.55 (25.16)	1.4	all real	—
	Conservative (7–10)	4.05** (1.72)	141.3	[0.62, 7.47]	8.73*** (0.92)
CDU Vote intention (pp)	Pooled	-2.47 (1.95)	96.6	[-6.39, 1.39]	-1.84*** (0.69)
	Liberal (0–4)	28.42 (41.57)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	21.08 (36.58)	1.4	all real	—
	Conservative (7–10)	-2.12 (1.54)	141.3	[-5.20, 0.91]	-2.93*** (0.84)
AfD Thermometer (SD)	Pooled	0.095** (0.044)	96.6	[0.006, 0.181]	0.213*** (0.015)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.401 (0.665)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	0.676 (0.787)	1.4	all real	—
	Conservative (7–10)	0.098*** (0.035)	141.3	[0.028, 0.169]	0.189*** (0.019)
CDU Thermometer (SD)	Pooled	-0.022 (0.046)	96.6	[-0.111, 0.072]	-0.071*** (0.016)
	Liberal (0–4)	1.509 (1.739)	0.9	disconnected	—
	Moderate (5–6)	0.180 (0.698)	1.4	all real	—
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.040 (0.035)	141.3	[-0.108, 0.031]	-0.110*** (0.020)
AfD Support index (SD)	Pooled	0.050 (0.043)	96.6	[-0.039, 0.132]	0.201*** (0.016)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.167 (0.526)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	0.660 (0.740)	1.4	all real	—
	Conservative (7–10)	0.065* (0.035)	141.3	[-0.006, 0.133]	0.182*** (0.020)
CDU Support index (SD)	Pooled	-0.056 (0.046)	96.6	[-0.149, 0.037]	-0.060*** (0.017)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.930 (1.180)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	0.665 (0.889)	1.4	all real	—
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.046 (0.037)	141.3	[-0.119, 0.027]	-0.096*** (0.020)
AfD Campaign help (SD)	Pooled	-0.019 (0.045)	96.6	[-0.116, 0.065]	0.152*** (0.017)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.776 (0.988)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	0.558 (0.656)	1.4	all real	—
	Conservative (7–10)	0.011 (0.038)	141.3	[-0.067, 0.084]	0.157*** (0.021)
CDU Campaign help (SD)	Pooled	-0.035 (0.048)	96.6	[-0.131, 0.061]	-0.022 (0.018)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.471 (0.821)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	0.707 (0.905)	1.4	all real	—
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.018 (0.040)	141.3	[-0.096, 0.062]	-0.055*** (0.021)
AfD Donation willingness (SD)	Pooled	-0.011 (0.047)	96.6	[-0.110, 0.080]	0.115*** (0.018)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.295 (0.728)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	1.406 (1.382)	1.4	disconnected	—
	Conservative (7–10)	0.019 (0.037)	141.3	[-0.056, 0.092]	0.077*** (0.022)
CDU Donation willingness (SD)	Pooled	-0.076 (0.048)	96.6	[-0.174, 0.018]	-0.064*** (0.019)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.103 (0.773)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	1.154 (1.261)	1.4	disconnected	—
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.040 (0.038)	141.3	[-0.116, 0.034]	-0.065*** (0.024)
AfD Newsletter opening (SD)	Pooled	0.009 (0.046)	96.6	[-0.084, 0.099]	0.019 (0.023)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.060 (0.275)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.395 (0.527)	1.4	all real	—
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.004 (0.044)	141.3	[-0.094, 0.082]	0.007 (0.029)
CDU Newsletter opening (SD)	Pooled	0.008 (0.047)	96.6	[-0.087, 0.103]	0.019 (0.019)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.171 (0.582)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.485 (0.774)	1.4	all real	—
	Conservative (7–10)	0.007 (0.042)	141.3	[-0.076, 0.091]	0.007 (0.021)
Turnout likelihood (SD)	Pooled	0.005 (0.047)	96.6	[-0.089, 0.097]	0.042** (0.017)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.605 (1.050)	0.9	all real	—
	Moderate (5–6)	0.110 (0.808)	1.4	all real	—
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.012 (0.035)	141.3	[-0.083, 0.056]	0.080*** (0.024)

Notes: 2SLS effects of the pre-registered gap measure, the absolute distance between the respondent's attitude and the position of the closest party other than the AfD, instrumented by the signal, with the controls of equation (1). The last column reports LLS for the gap at the main bandwidth on positive gap-updaters (955 in the full sample, 751 among conservative voters), with the controls of the main LLS designs. Robust standard errors (Bayesian bootstrap for LLS) in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$.

Table F.5: Equally Weighted Support Index

		RF		2SLS		LLS	
Outcome	Population	PCA (main)	Equal weights	PCA (main)	Equal weights	PCA (main)	Equal weights
AfD support index (SD)	Pooled	0.013	0.011	0.026	0.023	0.059**	0.061**
		(0.011)	(0.011)	(0.023)	(0.023)	(0.027)	(0.027)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.006	-0.005	-0.013	-0.010	0.002	-0.002
		(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.038)	(0.036)	(0.039)	(0.040)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.023	-0.022	-0.043	-0.040	0.023	0.024
		(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.035)	(0.034)	(0.037)	(0.036)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.026*	0.023	0.056*	0.049	0.104***	0.108***
		(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.031)	(0.031)	(0.036)	(0.036)
CDU support index (SD)	Pooled	-0.015	-0.014	-0.029	-0.029	-0.055*	-0.049*
		(0.012)	(0.012)	(0.024)	(0.024)	(0.029)	(0.029)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.036	0.030	0.072	0.060	0.022	0.023
		(0.025)	(0.024)	(0.049)	(0.048)	(0.046)	(0.045)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.024	-0.022	-0.043	-0.040	0.070	0.090
		(0.024)	(0.024)	(0.045)	(0.044)	(0.060)	(0.066)
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.019	-0.018	-0.040	-0.037	-0.091**	-0.086**
		(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.032)	(0.032)	(0.037)	(0.038)

Notes: The equally weighted index averages the five support-signed measures after standardizing each on the analysis sample, and is then standardized (Kling et al., 2007). LLS uses the same bootstrap draws as the main estimates. Robust standard errors (Bayesian bootstrap for LLS) in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$.

G Details on Heterogeneity Analysis

Table G.1 reports the main outcomes in East and West Germany: in the East, where 68 percent of respondents (2,073 of 3,037) hold conservative attitudes, a one-point more liberal signal raises AfD vote intention by 1.9 percentage points ($p = .010$), and in the West every estimator is close to zero. Table G.2 splits the vote effects by region within each attitude group; Section 6 discusses the pattern. With a signal-by-East interaction added to the specification of Table D.8, the AfD vote gradient across attitudes is 0.31 points per attitude point (SE 0.17, $p = .06$); within East Germany it is 0.52 (SE 0.23, $p = .02$) and within the West 0.07 (SE 0.24, $p = .76$). Table G.3 reports the three pre-registered moderators measured in the survey.

Table G.1: East and West Germany

	East Germany			West Germany			East minus West		
Outcome	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS
AfD vote intention (pp)	1.91***	4.07***	3.75**	-0.32	-0.60	0.11	2.23**	4.66**	3.64*
	(0.74)	(1.58)	(1.56)	(0.75)	(1.39)	(1.54)	(1.05)	(2.10)	(2.21)
CDU vote intention (pp)	-0.74	-1.58	-2.08	-0.50	-0.92	-0.62	-0.25	-0.66	-1.46
	(0.62)	(1.32)	(1.46)	(0.85)	(1.59)	(1.97)	(1.06)	(2.06)	(2.50)
AfD thermometer (sd)	0.044***	0.094***	0.076**	-0.010	-0.019	-0.025	0.054**	0.113**	0.101**
	(0.016)	(0.033)	(0.036)	(0.017)	(0.032)	(0.036)	(0.023)	(0.047)	(0.051)
CDU thermometer (sd)	-0.011	-0.023	-0.042	0.001	0.002	-0.085*	-0.012	-0.025	0.043
	(0.015)	(0.033)	(0.034)	(0.019)	(0.035)	(0.044)	(0.024)	(0.048)	(0.056)
AfD support index (sd)	0.030*	0.064**	0.076**	-0.017	-0.031	-0.031	0.047**	0.096**	0.107**
	(0.015)	(0.033)	(0.034)	(0.016)	(0.031)	(0.033)	(0.023)	(0.045)	(0.047)
CDU support index (sd)	-0.022	-0.047	-0.068*	-0.004	-0.007	-0.058	-0.018	-0.040	-0.011
	(0.015)	(0.033)	(0.037)	(0.020)	(0.036)	(0.047)	(0.025)	(0.049)	(0.061)
N (RF/2SLS) / LLS aggregation	3,037		1,506	2,003		1,065			

Notes: Estimates within East Germany (3,037 respondents, 68 percent conservative) and West Germany (2,003 respondents, 55 percent conservative), and their difference. Votes in percentage points; other outcomes in standard deviations. Robust standard errors (Bayesian bootstrap for LLS) in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$.

Table G.2: Vote Effects by Region Within Attitude Groups

		East Germany		West Germany		East minus West	
Outcome	Population	RF	2SLS	RF	2SLS	RF	2SLS
AfD vote intention (pp)	Liberal (0–4)	-0.02	-0.03	-1.77*	-3.38*	1.76	3.35
		(1.38)	(2.94)	(0.94)	(1.92)	(1.67)	(3.51)
	Moderate (5–6)	-1.32	-2.55	1.10	1.84	-2.41	-4.39
		(1.44)	(2.89)	(1.02)	(1.71)	(1.77)	(3.36)
	Conservative (7–10)	2.51***	5.59***	-0.06	-0.11	2.56*	5.70*
		(0.92)	(2.09)	(1.14)	(2.22)	(1.47)	(3.05)
CDU vote intention (pp)	Liberal (0–4)	-0.41	-0.87	2.58	4.91	-2.99	-5.79
		(1.44)	(3.08)	(1.65)	(3.14)	(2.20)	(4.39)
	Moderate (5–6)	-2.05	-3.97	0.18	0.31	-2.23	-4.28
		(1.51)	(2.97)	(1.74)	(2.93)	(2.30)	(4.17)
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.27	-0.61	-1.99*	-3.85*	1.72	3.25
		(0.75)	(1.68)	(1.14)	(2.23)	(1.36)	(2.79)
AfD + CDU vote intention (pp)	Liberal (0–4)	-0.43	-0.90	0.80	1.53	-1.23	-2.44
		(1.77)	(3.82)	(1.74)	(3.28)	(2.48)	(5.03)
	Moderate (5–6)	-3.36*	-6.52*	1.28	2.15	-4.64*	-8.67*
		(1.85)	(3.82)	(1.83)	(3.08)	(2.60)	(4.91)
	Conservative (7–10)	2.23**	4.98**	-2.05	-3.96	4.28***	8.95***
		(0.91)	(2.10)	(1.30)	(2.58)	(1.59)	(3.33)

Notes: Effects on vote intention in percentage points within each attitude group and region; the AfD + CDU rows are the net flow into the two parties, as in Table D.5; robust standard errors in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$. RF effects are per one-point more liberal signal; 2SLS effects are per one-point more liberal perceived CDU position. Controls of equation (1) without the East indicator. The East-minus-West difference and its standard error treat the two regional estimates as independent. Samples: 433, 531, and 2,073 liberal, moderate, and conservative respondents in the East; 390, 521, and 1,092 in the West.

Table G.3: Additional Heterogeneity Dimensions

		High / yes			Low / no			Difference		
Moderator	Outcome	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS
Immigration important (4–5 vs 1–3)	AfD vote intention (pp)	1.62**	3.33**	3.92**	0.21	0.40	-2.58*	1.41	2.93	6.50***
		(0.66)	(1.35)	(1.63)	(0.85)	(1.63)	(1.55)	(1.07)	(2.12)	(2.32)
	CDU vote intention (pp)	-0.88	-1.81	-2.90**	-0.04	-0.07	0.49	-0.84	-1.74	-3.39
		(0.61)	(1.25)	(1.39)	(0.88)	(1.70)	(2.40)	(1.07)	(2.11)	(2.83)
	AfD support index (sd)	0.020	0.040	0.077**	0.012	0.023	-0.078**	0.008	0.017	0.155***
		(0.014)	(0.029)	(0.035)	(0.018)	(0.034)	(0.038)	(0.022)	(0.044)	(0.053)
	CDU support index (sd)	-0.012	-0.025	-0.082**	-0.018	-0.035	0.004	0.006	0.011	-0.086
		(0.014)	(0.029)	(0.034)	(0.021)	(0.041)	(0.054)	(0.025)	(0.050)	(0.064)
Issue voter (yes vs no)	AfD vote intention (pp)	2.06***	4.09***	0.95	0.04	0.08	4.82**	2.02*	4.00*	-3.87
		(0.70)	(1.39)	(1.51)	(0.82)	(1.73)	(1.96)	(1.08)	(2.22)	(2.43)
	CDU vote intention (pp)	-1.43**	-2.83**	-3.88***	0.29	0.61	-0.18	-1.72*	-3.45*	-3.70
		(0.67)	(1.32)	(1.40)	(0.77)	(1.61)	(1.80)	(1.02)	(2.08)	(2.29)
	AfD support index (sd)	0.033**	0.066**	-0.013	-0.010	-0.021	0.098**	0.044*	0.087*	-0.110**
		(0.016)	(0.031)	(0.033)	(0.017)	(0.035)	(0.043)	(0.023)	(0.047)	(0.053)
	CDU support index (sd)	-0.024	-0.047	-0.101**	-0.005	-0.010	-0.043	-0.019	-0.038	-0.059
		(0.017)	(0.033)	(0.040)	(0.017)	(0.036)	(0.040)	(0.024)	(0.049)	(0.057)
Delegate ideal (yes vs no)	AfD vote intention (pp)	0.65	1.17	2.54	1.42*	3.48*	2.85*	-0.76	-2.30	-0.30
		(0.73)	(1.30)	(1.69)	(0.78)	(1.89)	(1.67)	(1.06)	(2.30)	(2.31)
	CDU vote intention (pp)	-0.22	-0.40	0.50	-1.27	-3.12	-4.96***	1.05	2.72	5.47**
		(0.65)	(1.16)	(1.51)	(0.81)	(1.99)	(1.57)	(1.03)	(2.30)	(2.21)
	AfD support index (sd)	-0.001	-0.001	0.032	0.026	0.063	0.058	-0.026	-0.064	-0.026
		(0.015)	(0.027)	(0.037)	(0.017)	(0.041)	(0.039)	(0.023)	(0.049)	(0.054)
	CDU support index (sd)	-0.009	-0.017	-0.014	-0.024	-0.058	-0.147***	0.014	0.041	0.133**
		(0.016)	(0.028)	(0.037)	(0.019)	(0.046)	(0.040)	(0.025)	(0.054)	(0.055)

Notes: Vote effects in percentage points and support-index effects in standard deviations within each level of the moderators and the difference, high or yes minus low or no. Immigration important: stated importance of immigration of 4 or 5 on a 1–5 scale. Issue voter: the respondent's stated primary reason for the vote choice is that the party best represents their political opinions. Delegate ideal: the respondent thinks a member of parliament should follow the voters' opinion rather than their own. Region, is in Table G.1. Robust standard errors (Bayesian bootstrap for LLS) in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$.

H Follow-Up Study

We conducted an obfuscated follow-up approximately one week after each participant completed the main survey. The same survey firm distributed it, but the layout, tone, and wording were changed to make the connection difficult to detect. The follow-up contained only vote intentions, feeling thermometers, and the turnout item, standard questions that participants could plausibly encounter in an unrelated political survey; the thermometer used a 0–100 numerical response rather than the main survey's eleven options and asked how the respondent had felt about each party over the past year. Despite repeated invitations and a higher implied hourly payment than in the main survey, 2,182 of the 5,040 participants provided at least one follow-up outcome. Two timing rules, based on the recorded start times alone, define the analysis sample. First, 42 responses were started before the respondent's own main survey, when the firm's follow-up link reached panelists who had not yet completed it; these answers precede the treatment and cannot carry its effect. Second, 93 responses were started on or after election day, February 23, 2025, the last on March 12; a vote intention elicited after the election is a different object from one elicited during the campaign. The analysis sample is the remaining 2,047 respondents, and the 135 excluded responses count as nonresponse below. Table H.1 describes the respondents and shows that response is unrelated to the randomized signal. Table H.2 reports the follow-up effects for every outcome and population, Table H.3 the sensitivity of the vote effects to bandwidth and to inverse-response weights, and Table H.4 the change in the vote effect between waves among respondents observed in both.

Table H.1: Follow-Up Response

Panel A. Who responded to the follow-up

	N	Mean age	% West	% male	Mean attitude	% AfD vote (main)
Respondents	2,047	46.1	47.7	55.3	7.02	30.7
Nonrespondents	2,993	48.5	34.3	52.3	7.16	32.0

Panel B. Reduced-form effect of the signal on follow-up response (pp per signal point)

Population	Coefficient	SE	*p*	*N*
Pooled	-0.66	0.61	.279	5,040
Liberal (0–4)	0.60	1.52	.694	823
Moderate (5–6)	-1.71	1.39	.217	1,052
Conservative (7–10)	-0.68	0.77	.377	3,165

Notes: Panel A compares the 2,047 respondents in the follow-up analysis sample with the other 2,993 participants, who include the 135 responses excluded by the timing rules. Panel B reports the reduced-form effect of the signal on the probability of being in the analysis sample, in percentage points, with the baseline controls and robust standard errors; a joint test of the three arm indicators in the pooled sample gives $p = .75$. Response weights for Table H.3 are the inverse of the predicted response probability from a logit on arm indicators, the baseline controls, attitude fixed effects, and the other-party priors, scaled to a mean of one; they range from 0.57 to 1.91.

Table H.2: Follow-Up Effects by Population

Outcome	Population	RF	2SLS	LLS
AfD vote intention (pp)	Pooled	-0.20 (0.84)	-0.37 (1.53)	0.88 (1.72)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.28 (1.40)	-0.54 (2.74)	2.18 (2.84)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.39 (1.34)	-0.62 (2.14)	1.71 (2.85)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.06 (1.15)	0.11 (2.16)	-0.90 (2.39)
CDU vote intention (pp)	Pooled	-1.08 (0.80)	-1.96 (1.46)	-2.75 (1.91)
	Liberal (0–4)	1.23 (1.80)	2.39 (3.51)	2.37 (1.66)
	Moderate (5–6)	-3.29* (1.72)	-5.26* (2.78)	3.30 (4.52)
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.79 (1.02)	-1.47 (1.90)	-3.48 (2.47)
AfD thermometer (SD)	Pooled	-0.015 (0.019)	-0.027 (0.034)	0.020 (0.040)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.015 (0.036)	-0.029 (0.071)	0.048 (0.077)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.060* (0.034)	-0.096* (0.056)	-0.008 (0.064)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.007 (0.024)	0.013 (0.045)	0.044 (0.051)
CDU thermometer (SD)	Pooled	0.010 (0.019)	0.019 (0.034)	-0.031 (0.046)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.039 (0.041)	0.075 (0.081)	-0.092 (0.104)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.010 (0.039)	-0.016 (0.062)	0.146* (0.085)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.014 (0.023)	0.027 (0.044)	0.005 (0.053)
AfD vote-and-thermometer index (SD)	Pooled	-0.010 (0.018)	-0.019 (0.033)	0.021 (0.038)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.011 (0.033)	-0.022 (0.065)	0.050 (0.070)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.036 (0.030)	-0.058 (0.049)	0.015 (0.059)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.004 (0.024)	0.008 (0.045)	0.013 (0.051)
CDU vote-and-thermometer index (SD)	Pooled	-0.009 (0.019)	-0.016 (0.035)	-0.054 (0.047)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.038 (0.041)	0.074 (0.080)	-0.020 (0.068)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.050 (0.040)	-0.080 (0.064)	0.127 (0.099)
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.003 (0.024)	-0.005 (0.044)	-0.044 (0.058)
Turnout likelihood (SD)	Pooled	0.012 (0.019)	0.022 (0.035)	-0.008 (0.032)
	Liberal (0–4)	0.026 (0.048)	0.050 (0.094)	-0.027 (0.098)
	Moderate (5–6)	0.017 (0.040)	0.027 (0.064)	-0.080 (0.056)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.007 (0.024)	0.014 (0.045)	-0.009 (0.030)

Notes: Effects of the main-survey information on follow-up outcomes among follow-up respondents: 2,047 pooled, 351 liberal, 453 moderate, 1,243 conservative. The vote-and-thermometer index is the standardized first principal component of the two follow-up measures, each standardized on the follow-up analysis sample. RF effects are per one-point more liberal signal; 2SLS and LLS per one-point more liberal main-survey posterior. Robust standard errors (Bayesian bootstrap for LLS) in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$.

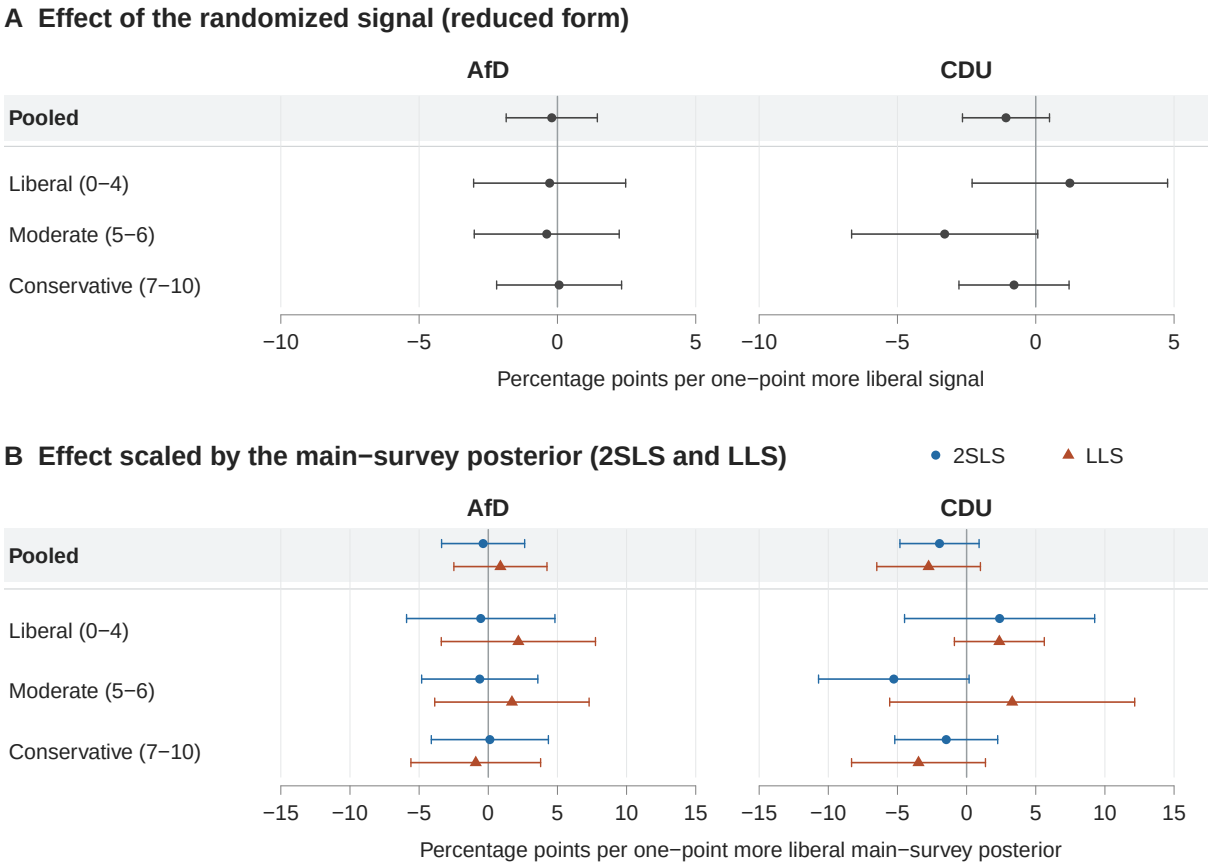


Figure H.1: Effects on Follow-Up Vote Intentions
Note: As in Figure 4, for the follow-up vote intentions among follow-up respondents.

Table H.3: Follow-Up Vote Effects: Sensitivity

		Main			LLS	Response-weighted		
Outcome	Population	RF	2SLS	LLS	$h = .15$	RF	2SLS	LLS
AfD vote intention (pp)	Pooled	-0.20	-0.37	0.88	0.40	-0.36	-0.65	0.88
		(0.84)	(1.53)	(1.72)	(1.53)	(0.88)	(1.58)	(1.76)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.28	-0.54	2.18	2.06	-0.53	-1.05	1.81
		(1.40)	(2.74)	(2.84)	(2.11)	(1.51)	(3.06)	(2.65)
	Moderate (5–6)	-0.39	-0.62	1.71	0.88	-0.51	-0.82	2.60
		(1.34)	(2.14)	(2.85)	(2.52)	(1.35)	(2.17)	(3.11)
	Conservative (7–10)	0.06	0.11	-0.90	-1.27	-0.17	-0.32	-0.72
		(1.15)	(2.16)	(2.39)	(2.24)	(1.19)	(2.18)	(2.40)
CDU vote intention (pp)	Pooled	-1.08	-1.96	-2.75	-1.75	-1.01	-1.81	-3.26*
		(0.80)	(1.46)	(1.91)	(1.55)	(0.82)	(1.47)	(1.90)
	Liberal (0–4)	1.23	2.39	2.37	5.49*	0.96	1.91	2.51
		(1.80)	(3.51)	(1.66)	(3.13)	(1.78)	(3.55)	(1.59)
	Moderate (5–6)	-3.29*	-5.26*	3.30	1.13	-3.19*	-5.08*	2.99
		(1.72)	(2.78)	(4.52)	(3.22)	(1.68)	(2.71)	(4.08)
	Conservative (7–10)	-0.79	-1.47	-3.48	-2.97	-0.58	-1.06	-3.55
		(1.02)	(1.90)	(2.47)	(2.09)	(1.05)	(1.92)	(2.49)

Notes: Main: as in Table H.2. $h = .15$: LLS at the wider bandwidth. Response-weighted: estimates weighted by the inverse predicted response probability of Table H.1; LLS inference conditions on the estimated weights. Vote effects in percentage points; robust standard errors (Bayesian bootstrap for LLS) in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$.

Table H.4: Change in Vote Effects Between Waves

		Main survey			Follow-up			Change (follow-up minus main)		
Outcome	Population	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS	RF	2SLS	LLS
AfD vote intention (pp)	Pooled	0.07	0.14	1.64	-0.20	-0.37	0.88	-0.28	-0.51	-0.76
		(0.83)	(1.51)	(1.71)	(0.84)	(1.53)	(1.72)	(0.47)	(0.86)	(0.97)
	Liberal (0–4)	-0.89	-1.73	2.23	-0.28	-0.54	2.18	0.61	1.18	-0.05
		(1.37)	(2.74)	(2.62)	(1.40)	(2.74)	(2.84)	(0.95)	(1.87)	(1.06)
	Moderate (5–6)	-1.43	-2.29	1.04	-0.39	-0.62	1.71	1.04	1.67	0.67
		(1.26)	(2.05)	(2.84)	(1.34)	(2.14)	(2.85)	(0.99)	(1.60)	(1.77)
	Conservative (7–10)	1.11	2.09	-0.62	0.06	0.11	-0.90	-1.05	-1.97	-0.29
		(1.15)	(2.15)	(2.27)	(1.15)	(2.16)	(2.39)	(0.66)	(1.25)	(1.16)
CDU vote intention (pp)	Pooled	-1.26	-2.30	-1.77	-1.08	-1.96	-2.75	0.19	0.34	-0.98
		(0.81)	(1.47)	(1.93)	(0.80)	(1.46)	(1.91)	(0.50)	(0.90)	(1.16)
	Liberal (0–4)	1.33	2.58	2.15	1.23	2.39	2.37	-0.10	-0.19	0.22
		(1.73)	(3.37)	(1.55)	(1.80)	(3.51)	(1.66)	(1.19)	(2.31)	(0.68)
	Moderate (5–6)	-2.19	-3.49	5.09	-3.29*	-5.26*	3.30	-1.11	-1.77	-1.80
		(1.71)	(2.73)	(4.40)	(1.72)	(2.78)	(4.52)	(1.19)	(1.92)	(1.60)
	Conservative (7–10)	-1.44	-2.69	-2.28	-0.79	-1.47	-3.48	0.65	1.22	-1.20
		(1.03)	(1.94)	(2.33)	(1.02)	(1.90)	(2.47)	(0.60)	(1.14)	(1.43)

Notes: Effects on the main-survey vote intention, the follow-up vote intention, and their difference, all estimated on the respondents observed in both waves, so that the change is a within-person comparison. Percentage points; robust standard errors (Bayesian bootstrap for LLS) in parentheses; *, **, *** denote $p < .10, .05, .01$. For LLS the change uses paired bootstrap draws.

I Questionnaire (Translated from German)

This appendix reproduces the main survey in the order in which participants saw it, translated from German. The screenshots show the English translation of each screen; Figure 2 shows the information screen in each of the four treatment arms. The full instruments, in German and in English translation, are included in the replication package.

I.1 Pre-Treatment Block (Fixed Order, Same in All Treatments)

The first screen told participants that the study asks questions about political topics and takes about ten minutes, that there are no right or wrong answers when they are asked for their personal opinion, that their answers are completely anonymous, that "we are independent researchers" and "all information you receive during this study is true," and that participants must be German citizens and at least 18 years old. Participants then gave their consent and completed a CAPTCHA. An attention check asked them to select "8" in answer to the question of how many days a week has; participants who selected another answer were screened out. Participants then reported their gender, age, educational attainment, and federal state of residence; participants younger than 18 and participants in a demographic quota cell that was already full were screened out.

The next screen measured the participant's own immigration attitude and prior beliefs about the parties' positions:

> *Some want to facilitate immigration opportunities for foreigners, others want to restrict immigration opportunities for foreigners. What is your personal opinion on the topic of immigration opportunities for foreigners? Please use the following scale from 0 to 10. A value of 0 on the scale means that, in your opinion, immigration opportunities should be very strongly facilitated. A value of 10 means that, in your opinion, immigration opportunities should be very strongly restricted. You can use the values between 0 and 10 to grade your opinion.*



Figure I.1: Own Immigration Attitude

> *What do you think, which policy does . . . represent?*

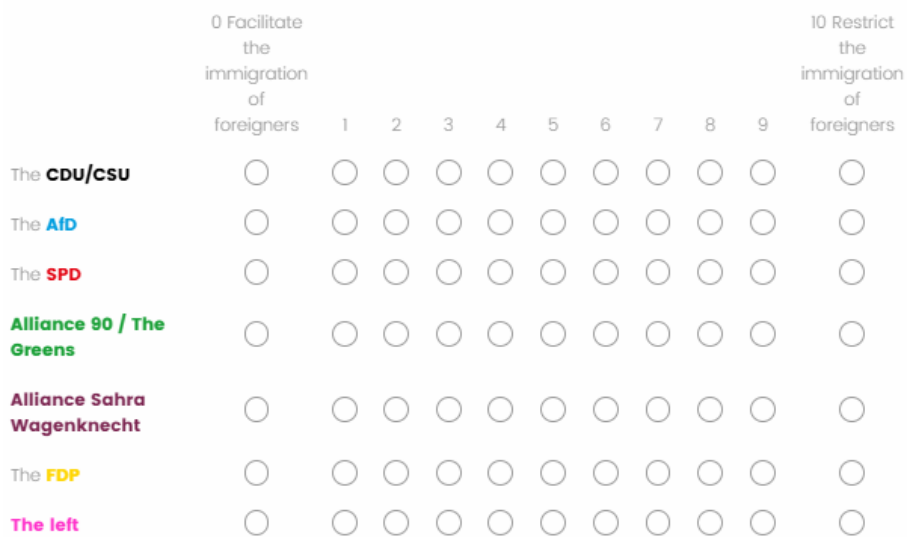


Figure I.2: Prior Beliefs about the Parties' Immigration Positions

The next screen introduced the information as follows. The details were expanded by default.

> *Scientists have long been researching how to measure the positions of parties. As recent studies show, one valid method is to evaluate the answers of a party's politicians in an anonymous survey.*
>
> *We measured the positions of the German parties on immigration with this method. For this purpose, we evaluated the answers of some Bundestag candidates to the same question we just asked you.*
>
> *[Click here for details] These are candidates in the 2021 Bundestag election. Therefore, the candidates of the Sahra Wagenknecht Alliance have not yet been surveyed. We will give you information on the answers of 588 candidates. They are distributed across the parties as follows. CDU/CSU: 11, AfD: 58, SPD: 117, Alliance 90/The Greens: 163, FDP: 117, The Left: 122.*
>
> *The next page shows the results.*

I.2 Treatment Block (Fixed Order, Randomized Across Treatments)

The next screen provided the randomized information. The following text appeared above the figure in all treatments:

> *The following figure illustrates the positions of German parties. The colored arrows show the middle position (median) of Bundestag candidates of the respective party. The gray arrow shows your own position, which you indicated earlier.*
>
> *[Click here for details] The middle position (also called median) is defined as follows: if you rank all positions by size, it lies exactly in the middle. Example: 5 CDU candidates have the positions 5, 6, 7, 8, 8. Then the middle position is 7, because two positions are smaller and two are larger than 7.*

The details were collapsed by default. The example quoted is the one shown in the arm in which the CDU position is 7; in each arm, the example's positions were centered on the CDU value shown. The rest of the screen differed across arms in (i) the position of the CDU/CSU arrow and (ii) the verbal description of the CDU's position below the figure, which read "slightly facilitate," "leave unchanged," "slightly restrict," and "restrict" immigration opportunities in the arms with CDU positions 4, 5, 6, and 7. The gray arrow was placed at the participant's own pre-treatment position. Figure I.3 shows the screen in the arm with CDU position 7 for a participant at position 8.

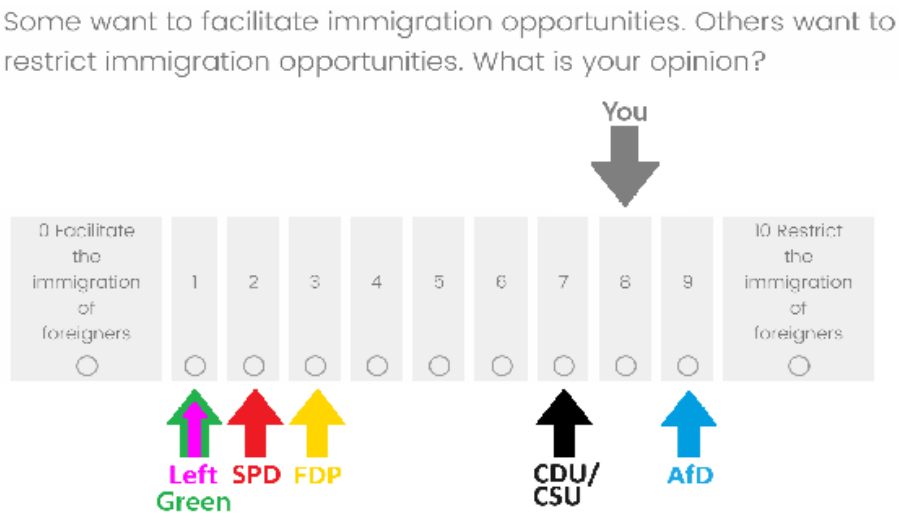


Figure I.3: Information Screen, Treatment Arm with CDU Position 7

I.3 Post-Treatment Beliefs (Same in All Treatments)

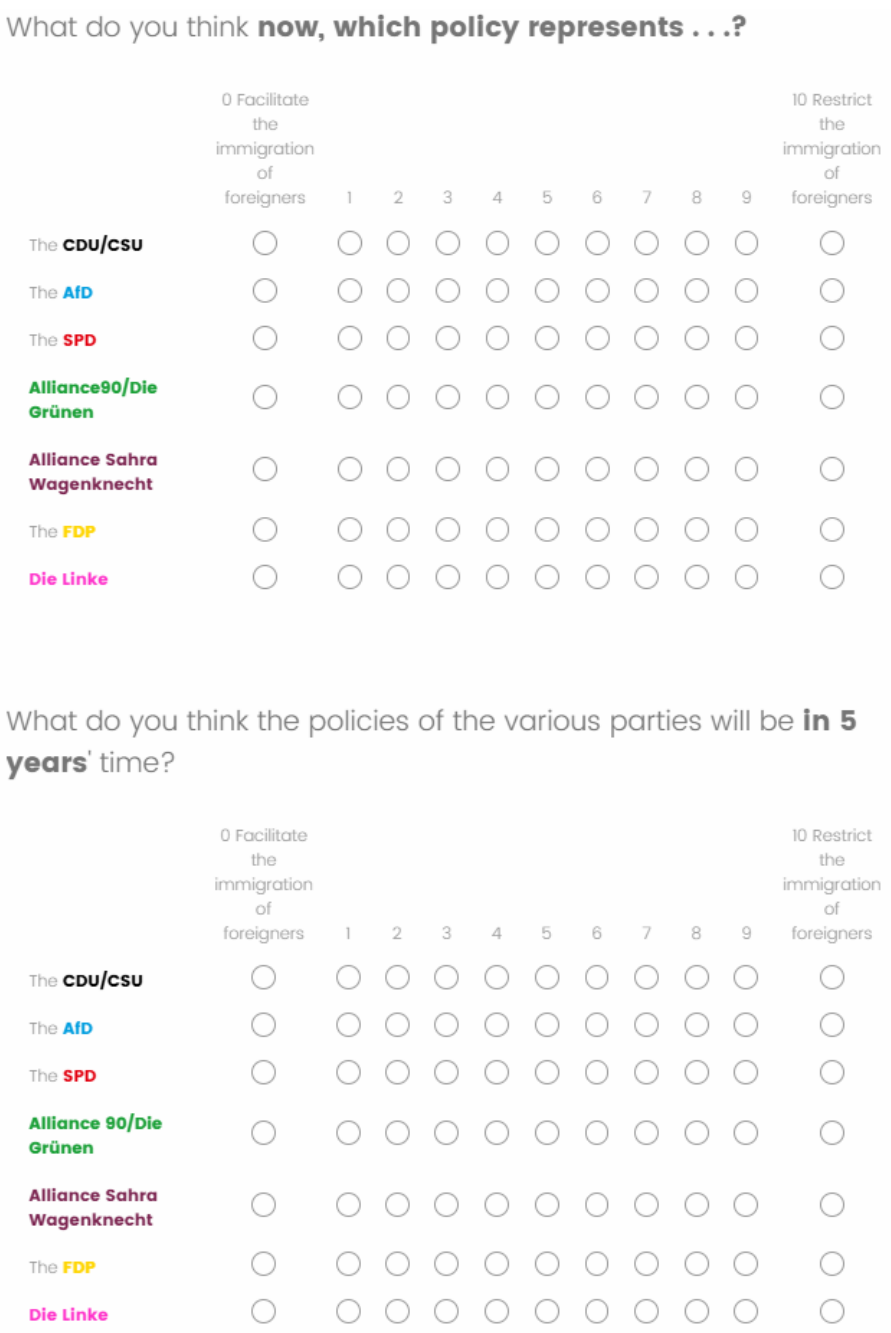


Figure I.4: Posterior Beliefs about the Parties' Current and Future Immigration Positions

I.4 Main Outcomes (Randomized Order, Same in All Treatments)

The four blocks Voting, Feeling Thermometer, Newsletter, and Campaign Support appeared in random order; the order of the questions within each block was fixed. The two donation blocks followed, in random order.

Voting

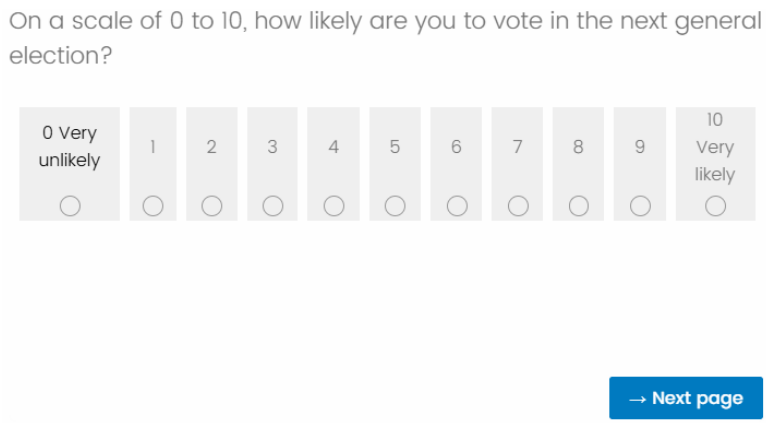


Figure I.5: Turnout Likelihood

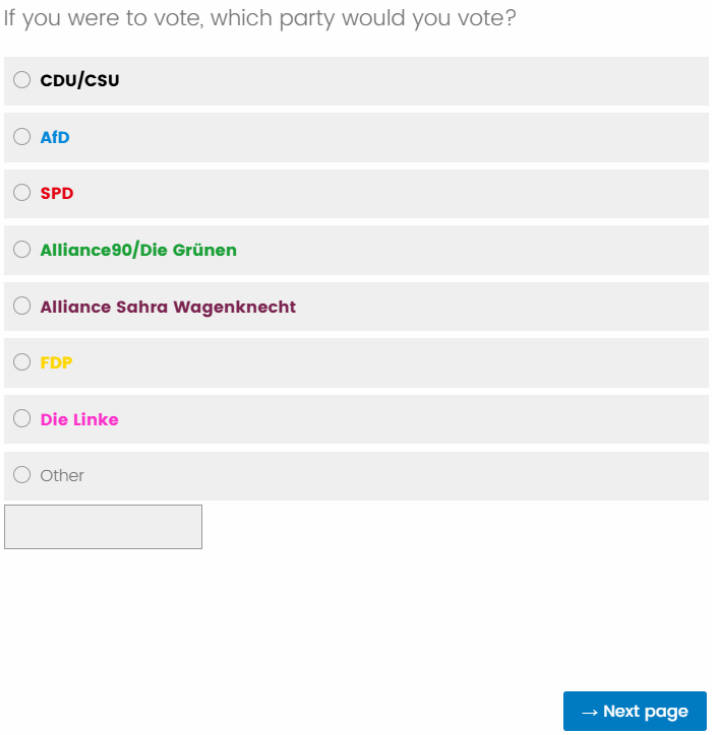


Figure I.6: Vote Intention

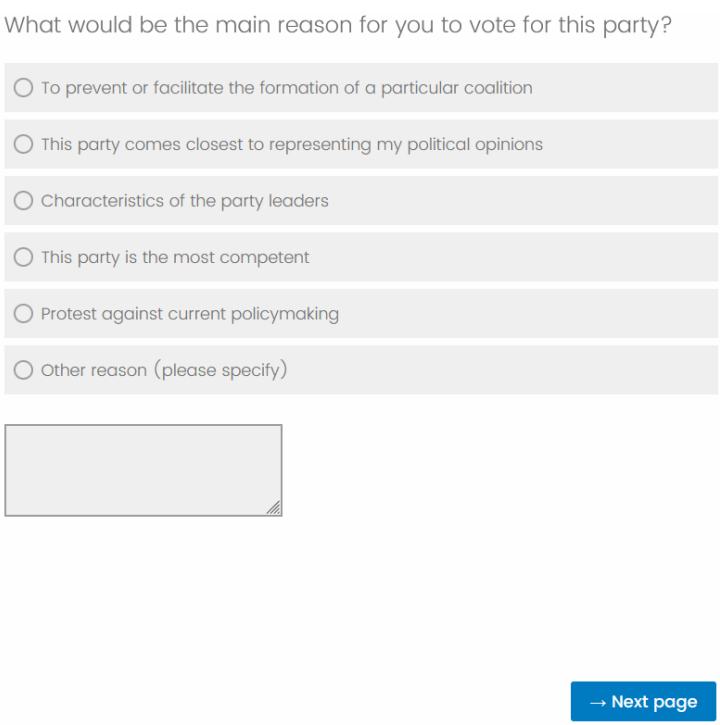


Figure I.7: Reason for Vote Choice

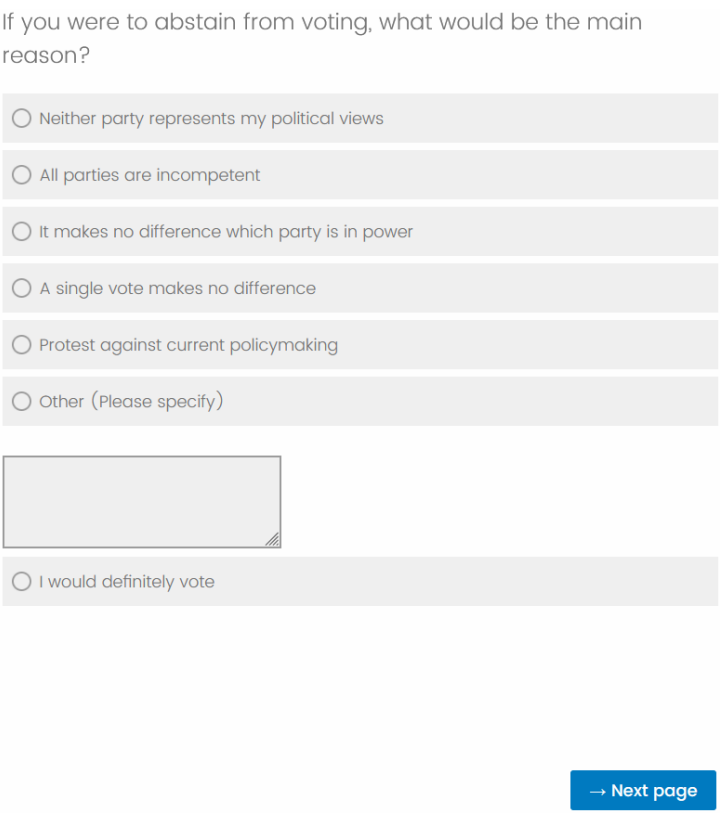


Figure I.8: Reason for Abstention

Feeling Thermometer

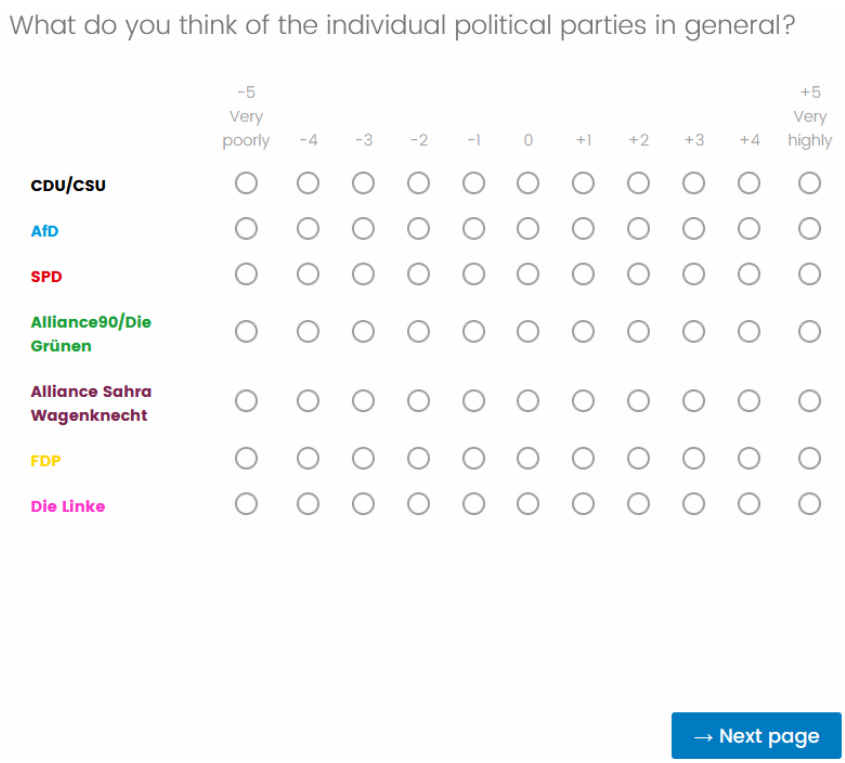


Figure I.9: Feeling Thermometer

Newsletter

> *You now have the opportunity to subscribe to a party's newsletter. For this purpose, you can use the following links. Each of the links will take you to a page where you can subscribe to the corresponding newsletter. This window will not close. You do not have to click on any of the links to continue with the survey. We will in no case learn whether you subscribe to one of the newsletters.*
>
> *Click here to subscribe to the newsletter of the CDU [the AfD; the SPD; Alliance 90/The Greens; the Sahra Wagenknecht Alliance; the FDP; The Left]*

The newsletter outcome records whether participants open a party's subscription page, not whether they complete a subscription.

Campaign Support

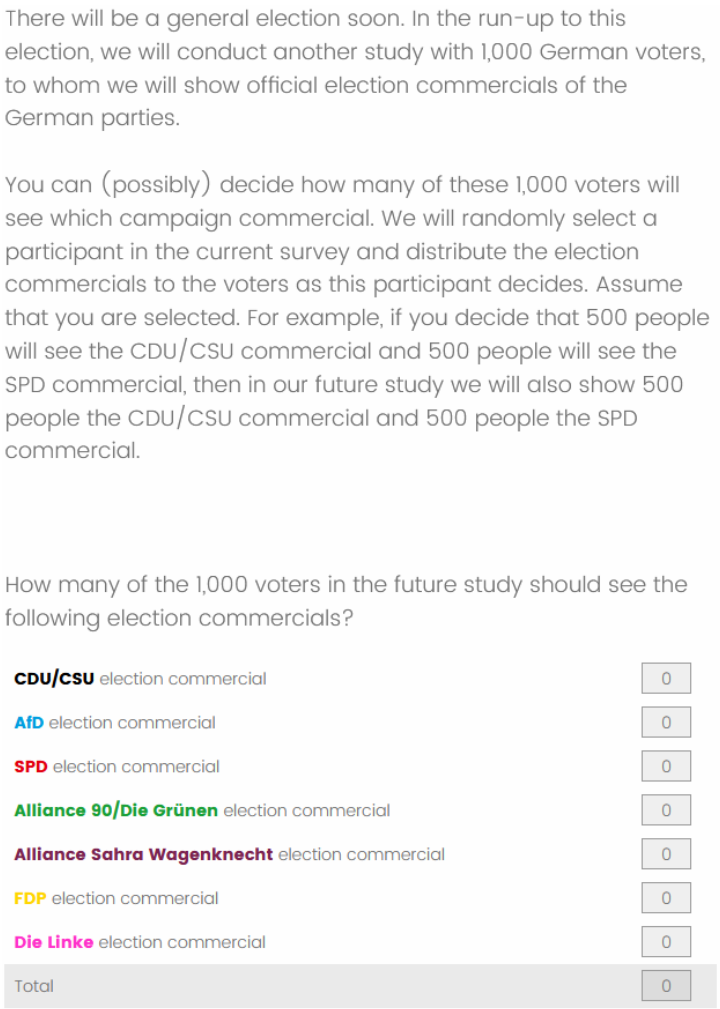


Figure I.10: Campaign Support

Donations

The CDU block opened as follows; the AfD block was identical with the AfD in place of the CDU/CSU.

> *On the following pages, we will ask you several questions. In each of these questions, you can decide whether you would rather receive an additional bonus and agree that we transfer a donation of €5 to the CDU/CSU, or receive no additional bonus and thereby prevent us from making the donation. After the survey, we will randomly select five participants. For each of these participants, we will randomly select one of these questions and implement their decision. Each of your decisions can therefore have real consequences. Your answers to these questions, as to all other questions, are completely anonymous.*
>
> *Which alternative do you prefer?*
>
> ◦ *You receive €50 and the CDU/CSU receives €5*
>
> ◦ *You receive €0 and the CDU/CSU receives €0*

Following the staircase method of Falk et al. (2018), each block consisted of four or five such questions, which elicit the minimum additional compensation a participant requires to permit a real €5 donation to the party on their behalf; higher required compensation indicates lower support. Participants who permitted the donation for a payment of €50 were next offered €20, and those who did not were offered €80. Depending on that answer, the third question offered €5, €35, €65, or €95, and the fourth €0, €10, €30, €40, €60, €70, €90, or €105. Participants who did not permit the donation for €105 were asked a fifth question offering €200.

I.5 Mechanism Questions (Randomized Order, Same in All Treatments)

The next two screens, in random order, asked for felt representation and for expectations about the election. Felt representation by the CDU is the CDU/CSU row of Figure I.11.

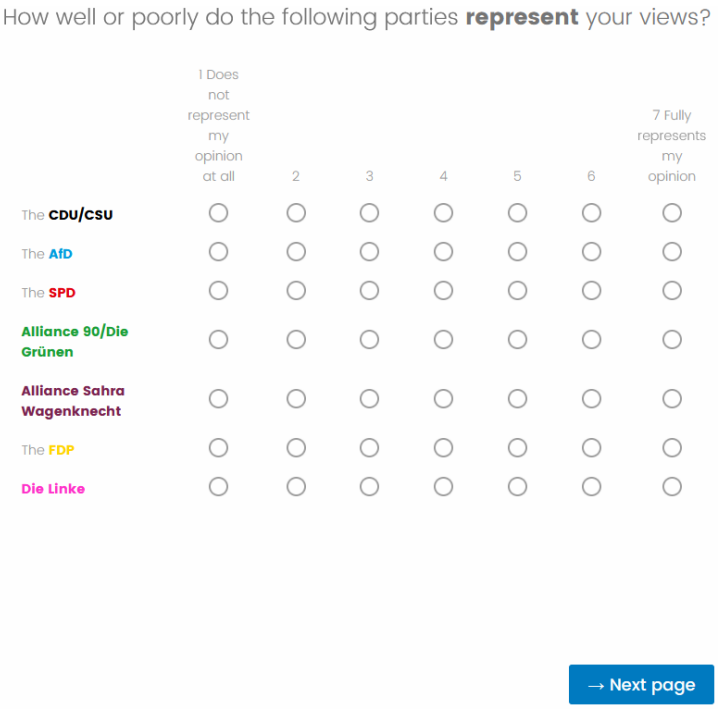


Figure I.11: Felt Representation

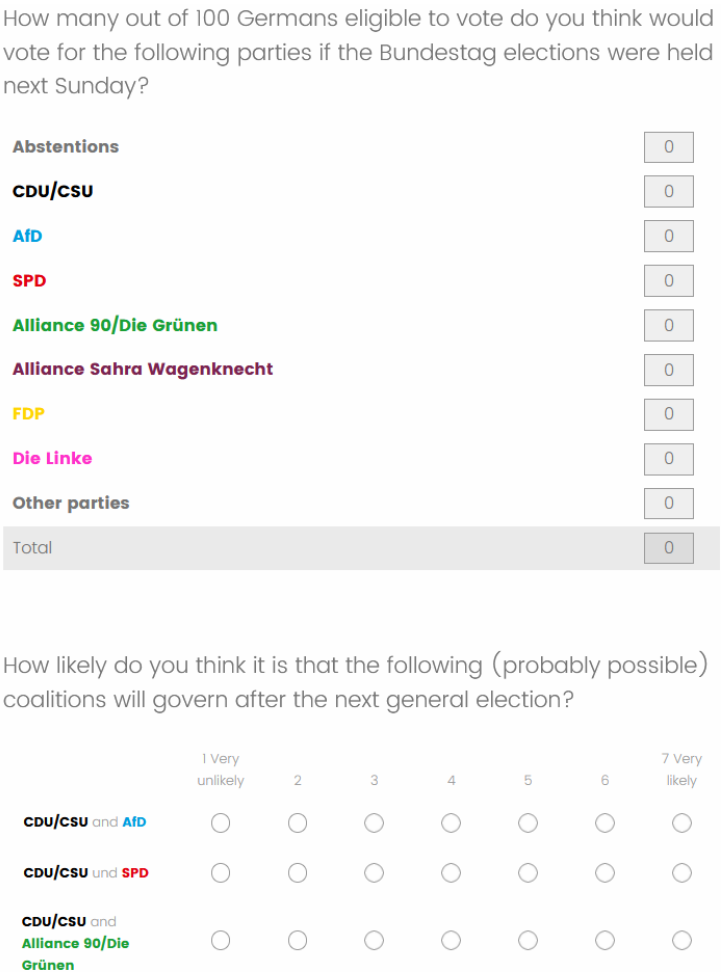


Figure I.12: Expected Vote Shares and Coalitions

I.6 Final Block (Fixed Order, Same in All Treatments)



Figure I.13: Final Block, First Screen

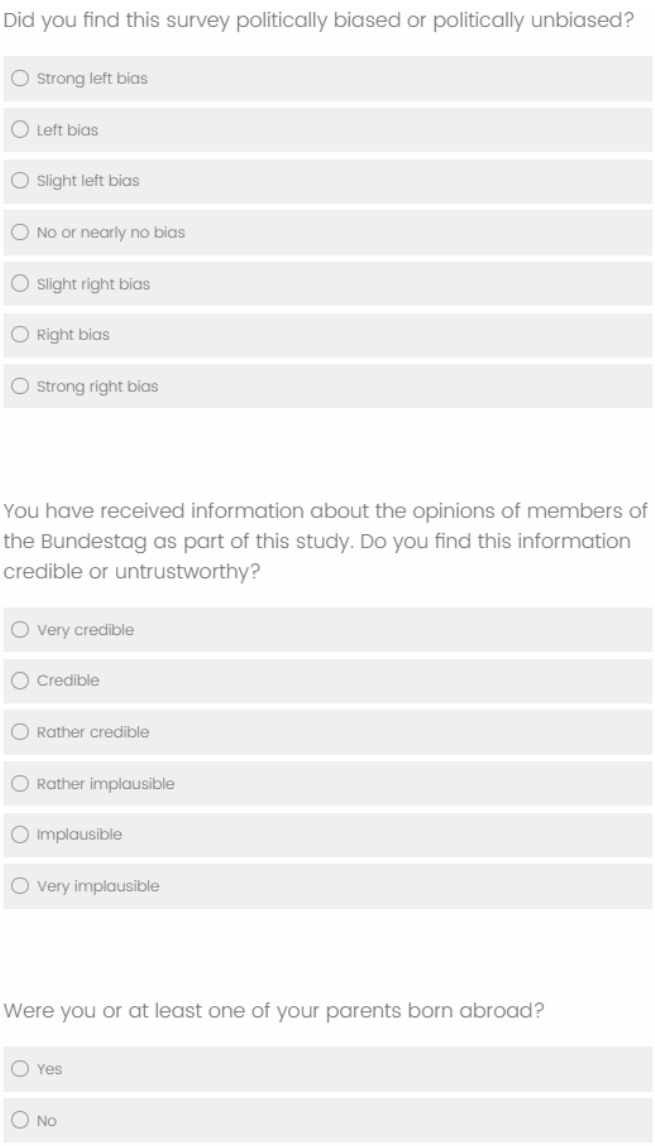


Figure I.14: Final Block, Second Screen